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DO POLITICAL OPPOSITES ATTRACT?

An experimental study of political homogamy in a multi-party system

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Abstract

Research on affective polarization consistently shows that political party affiliations extend beyond the ballot box and influence our social relationships. Relatedly, research on political homogamy has long documented that couples tend to be more politically similar than expected by chance. Recent experimental studies suggest that this to some extent stems from direct political matching, that is, the active selection of romantic partners based on shared political views. However, these studies have been largely confined to two-party systems, leaving a gap in our understanding of how political preferences shape partner selection when individuals face multiple groups of out-partisans. The present study addresses this by conducting a vignette survey experiment in the multi-party context of Sweden, in which respondents evaluated hypothetical potential partners varying in party affiliation and nonpolitical attributes. In line with previous research, respondents evaluate co-partisans more favorably than out-partisans. Building on the affective polarization literature, the study further shows that romantic interest decreases with ideological distance, while out-bloc affiliation and support for populist radical right parties are associated with additional negative effects. These findings contribute to the literature on political homogamy and direct political matching, as well as research on affective polarization. Beyond their scientific relevance, the findings suggest that political divisions may extend into intimate life in ways that could reinforce polarization over time, and given growing gender differences in political orientations, complicate heterosexual partner formation.

Keywords: affective polarization, direct political matching, multi-party systems, political homogamy, survey experiment

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1. Introduction

In recent years, *affective polarization*, the extent to which individuals feel sympathy toward co-partisans and animosity toward out-partisans (Wagner, 2021), has become one of the most widely studied phenomena in political science. Research suggests that its consequences extend well beyond the political arena, shaping social relations such as friendship formation (Iyengar et al., 2019), roommate choice (Shafranek, 2021), and whom individuals want their children to marry (Iyengar et al., 2012). Romantic relationships, arguably the most intimate social bond of all, appear to be no exception. Indeed, research has long documented that couples tend to be more politically homogenous than would be expected by chance, a pattern known as *political homogamy* (Lampard, 1997). While such similarity may arise through several mechanisms, not all of which are conscious, evidence suggests that *direct political matching*, the active selection of romantic partners based on shared political views (Hudde & Grunow, 2025), contributes to this pattern.

The existence of direct political matching has been documented across a wide range of contexts (e.g., Alford et al., 2011; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Hudde & Grunow, 2025). However, little is known about how political preferences shape partner selection in multi-party systems, where individuals face not one but several groups of out-partisans. Studies of existing couples in such settings remain largely descriptive (Hudde & Grunow, 2025), while research on dating processes and experimental studies have been confined to two-party contexts (e.g., Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017) or focused solely on the two major parties (Sleiman et al., 2025). The idea that individuals differentiate between out-partisan groups has gained increasing attention in affective polarization research (e.g., Gidron et al., 2023; Hartevelde, 2021), yet this insight has not been extended to partner selection. The overall research question guiding this study is therefore: *To what extent does political (dis)similarity influence romantic interest in potential partners in multi-party systems?*

To address this question, I conduct a survey experiment in Sweden, a multi-party system with average levels of affective polarization (Reiljan & Ryan, 2021; Wagner, 2021). Respondents are presented with profiles of hypothetical individuals varying in political affiliation and asked to rate their level of romantic interest. Building on previous research on direct political matching (e.g., Alford et al., 2011; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Hudde & Grunow, 2025), I hypothesize that respondents will evaluate co-partisans more favorably than out-partisans. Drawing on the affective polarization literature, I further expect evaluations to become more negative with increasing ideological distance (Erkel & Turkenburg, 2022; Hartevelde, 2021),

that out-bloc affiliation carries an independent penalty (Kekkonen & Ylä-Anttila, 2021; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021), and that populist radical right (PRR) profiles will be evaluated particularly negatively (Gidron et al., 2023; Hartevelt et al., 2022). All four hypotheses are supported, suggesting that direct political matching in multi-party systems cannot be explained by the logic of two-party systems alone.

These findings have implications beyond the study of partner selection. Direct political matching is often understood as a behavioral extension of affective polarization, yet it can also function as one of its drivers. Individuals with similar political orientations are more likely to raise children who share those views, whether through socialization, genetics, or some combination of both (Alford et al., 2011; Klofstad et al., 2013). Over time, such intergenerational transmission of attitudes may deepen divisions between political camps, push more individuals toward the ideological extremes, and ultimately intensify affective polarization (Iyengar et al., 2018; Klofstad et al., 2013). Beyond social sorting – which may itself be normatively concerning – affective polarization has been associated with a range of adverse democratic consequences, including democratic backsliding (Orhan, 2022), political violence (Berntzen, 2025), and reduced accountability (Sulmont & Incio, 2025), though these effects remain debated (e.g., Broockman et al., 2023; Voelkel et al., 2023).

Another implication concerns gender differences in political attitudes. Over the past decades, research across Western democracies has consistently shown that women are more likely to support left-wing parties, while men more often support right-wing parties (Abendschön & Steinmetz, 2014; Shorrocks, 2021), a pattern commonly referred to as the *modern gender gap* (Inglehart & Norris, 2000). In several countries, this divide has grown more pronounced, including Sweden, where the most recent general election in 2022 produced the largest gender gap in voting behavior in the country’s democratic history. Notably, this pattern was particularly strong among the youngest voters (aged 18-25) (Ahlbom & Karlsson, 2023). If men and women increasingly prefer different parties and individuals simultaneously seek politically similar partners, heterosexual partner formation may become more difficult over time, with potential consequences for broader demographic patterns.

The rest of this thesis proceeds as follows. First, I review the theoretical and empirical literature relevant to the research question and identify the key gap. Next, I describe the design and implementation of the survey experiment, as well as how it is used to test the hypotheses. This is followed by a presentation of the results. Finally, I conclude with a discussion of the findings, their broader implications, and directions for future research.

2. Theory and Previous research

In this section, I review research on homogamy and direct political matching to establish what is known about political similarity in partner selection and to identify the key research gap. I then draw on the affective polarization literature to develop hypotheses for the multi-party context and further situate the contributions of this study.

2.1. Political homogamy

The literature on *homogamy*, or *positive assortative mating* (Schwartz, 2013), is substantial and consistently shows that couples tend to be more similar than would be expected under random partner formation (for a summary see Kalmijn, 1998). The term has traditionally referred to marriage, but I use it more broadly to encompass romantic relationships regardless of marital status, following recent studies that adopt the same approach (e.g., Hudde & Grunow, 2025). While homogamy has been documented across a wide range of characteristics, this thesis focuses on political orientations, referred to here as *political homogamy*, a term previously used in the literature (e.g., Lampard, 1997). It should be noted, however, that not all previous studies use this specific term, but instead address the same phenomenon using more general concepts.

Some evidence for political homogamy comes from studies of existing couples that include political measures alongside other characteristics (e.g., Feng & Baker, 1994; Luo & Klohnen, 2005; Martin et al., 1986; Nagoshi et al., 1992; Watson et al., 2004). These studies show that similarity is stronger in social attitudes, including political ones, than in other internal traits, such as personality, psychological well-being, cognitive abilities, and emotional expression. Other studies of existing marriages focus directly on political homogamy (e.g., Alford et al., 2011; Coffé & Need, 2010; Hudde & Grunow, 2025; Iyengar et al., 2018; Lampard, 1997; Niemi et al., 1977). In this literature, homogamy is typically measured through party preference, as in this thesis, though it has also been documented for ideology (e.g., Alford et al., 2011) and attitudes toward specific issues (e.g., Niemi et al., 1977).

Beyond documenting its existence, previous research has sought to identify the mechanisms underlying political homogamy. Four main, non-mutually exclusive explanations are typically proposed.¹ First, *direct political matching* occurs when individuals actively select partners

¹ Terminology for these mechanisms varies across studies. In this thesis, I prioritize using terms that clearly capture each mechanism within the specific context of political homogamy.

who share their political views (Hudde & Grunow, 2025). Second, *indirect political matching* occurs when political similarity emerges as a by-product of partner selection based on nonpolitical traits correlated with politics (Hudde & Grunow, 2025). Third, *social homogamy* generates political similarity because people tend to meet and form relationships with constrained social and demographic groups (Alford et al., 2011; Luo & Klohn, 2005). Finally, *convergence* refers to partners becoming more politically alike over the course of their relationship (Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Iyengar et al., 2018).

2.1.2. Direct political matching

The primary mechanism of interest in this thesis is direct political matching, as it examines how explicit political orientations influence evaluations of potential partners. This thesis makes no claim that this mechanism is the sole driver of political homogamy. Still, the amount of evidence across contexts and methods suggests that it is an important one. Preferences for politically similar partners may be driven by both conscious and unconscious motivations that make politically similar individuals seem more attractive or desirable. For instance, differing political views may be seen as a potential source of conflict or as a sign that core values, important for future life decisions, do not align (Gerber et al., 2012; Graham et al., 2009). Political orientation may also serve as a proxy, or stereotypical cue, for other non-desirable characteristics (e.g., Rothschild et al., 2019). Moreover, these preferences may reflect affective polarization extending into romantic contexts (see Section 2.2).

Research has explored direct political matching through a variety of methodological approaches. First, several observational studies of existing couples identify this mechanism as the primary driver of political homogamy (Alford et al., 2011; Hudde & Grunow, 2025; Iyengar et al., 2018; Lampard, 1997). However, because direct political matching cannot be observed directly in data collected after relationship formation, it is typically inferred by controlling for alternative explanations, with any remaining political similarity attributed to active selection.² While such approaches can provide compelling suggestive evidence, they face inherent limitations in establishing causality. Beyond the scarcity of longitudinal data, this also stems from the inability to observe the counterfactual – namely, how couples would have differed if the same individuals had paired with alternative partners (Snyder, 1964).

² For example, Alford et al. (2011) stratify couples by marriage length to account for convergence, and by sociodemographic traits to account for indirect political matching and social homogamy. They find that political homogamy remains largely stable across groups, which is seen as evidence of direct political matching.

Next, studies using observational data from online dating platforms offer the advantage of capturing political preferences before relationships form. However, it remains unclear whether their findings generalize to other dating contexts or reflect long-term relationship formation (Hitsch et al., 2010; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Klofstad et al., 2012, 2013). Despite being conducted exclusively in the U.S., these studies yield inconsistent evidence. On one hand, research shows that users rarely express explicit political views in their profiles, suggesting limited scope for direct political matching (Hitsch et al., 2010; Klofstad et al., 2012). For instance, 57% of Klofstad et al.'s (2012) sample identified as “middle of the road”.³ On the other hand, behavioral analyses by both Hitsch et al. (2010) and Huber and Malhotra (2017) show that shared political orientations predict communication on these platforms, providing evidence consistent with direct political matching.

To address the causal limitations of observational studies, experimental research examines how political orientations shape partner evaluation in more controlled settings. While this approach provides a more direct assessment of active choice, it comes at the cost of reduced external validity. Both Luo and Zhang (2009) and Tidwell et al. (2013) conduct speed dating events in the U.S. and find that shared political preference does not increase romantic interest. However, the participants are not informed of each other's political preferences. While this may reflect real-world dating, in which individuals initially refrain from disclosing such information (as shown in Hitsch et al., 2010; Klofstad et al., 2012), political orientations may still influence partner selection once these preferences become known.

Other experimental studies employ survey-based vignette designs in which participants evaluate hypothetical profiles with randomly assigned political information. Nicholson et al. (2016) vary candidate preference, while Huber and Malhotra (2017) manipulate ideology, political interest, and several nonpolitical characteristics. Easton and Holbein (2021) conduct five experiments that vary party identification, ideology, and candidate preference. These vignette studies were all conducted in the U.S. In contrast, Sleiman et al. (2025) shift focus to the U.K. and employ a conjoint design in which respondents choose between pairs of profiles varying in party affiliation, tolerance toward out-partisans, and nonpolitical characteristics. Across all of these studies, respondents consistently favor politically similar profiles.

³ The low disclosure of political views in these U.S. studies may partly reflect the binary structure of the American party landscape, where centrist positions do not correspond to a specific political party. In multi-party systems, by contrast, “middle of the road” orientations often align with actual parties, which may potentially increase disclosure rates and alter the dynamics of direct political matching.

While the research reviewed above provides evidence of direct political matching across various dimensions, including ideology, candidate preference, specific issues, and party affiliation, important limitations remain with respect to the latter. Both observational and experimental research are heavily concentrated on two-party systems, particularly the U.S. Even Sleiman et al. (2025) who study a multi-party system like the UK, limit their focus to the two major parties. This leaves a gap in our understanding of how direct political matching functions in multi-party contexts, where individuals face a diverse landscape of out-party supporters rather than a single opposition. While observational studies of existing couples in these settings, such as Hudde and Grunow (2025) in Germany, identify common cross-party pairings, they remain largely descriptive and cannot disentangle the underlying logic of these patterns. It remains unclear whether individuals differentiate between different out-partisans; for instance, whether a social democratic party supporter is as likely to partner with someone supporting a traditional conservative party as with someone supporting a radical right party.

2.2. Affective polarization

This study also speaks to the literature on affective polarization. Several previous studies on direct political matching (e.g., Easton & Holbein, 2021; Iyengar et al., 2018; Nicholson et al., 2016) employ this as their primary theoretical framework. As mentioned, partner selection based on political similarity can be understood as a manifestation of affective polarization. In fact, in the Oxford Handbook on Affective Polarization, Carlin and Love (2025) reference several of the experimental studies on direct political matching mentioned above (specifically Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Nicholson et al., 2016) as examples of how to measure affective polarization. Building on this, I draw on the literature on affective polarization to develop hypotheses on direct political matching in multi-party systems, as this literature is more advanced in such contexts than research on political homogamy.

Research on affective polarization builds on studies that conceptualize partisanship as a social identity (Greene, 1999, 2004; Huddy et al., 2015; Iyengar et al., 2012). Wagner (2021, p.1) provides a widely cited definition of affective polarization as “the extent to which citizens feel sympathy towards partisan in-groups and antagonism towards partisan out-groups.” This definition highlights the two central components of the concept: positive in-group affect and negative out-group affect⁴ (Iyengar & Wagner, 2025). Affective polarization can be

⁴ Following the psychological definition, affect refers to “any experience of feeling or emotion” (APA Dictionary of Psychology).

understood as both an individual- and aggregate-level phenomenon, although research has most commonly focused on the latter (Wagner, 2021). This thesis primarily treats it as an individual-level phenomenon. Several scholars further distinguish between vertical and horizontal affective polarization (Harteveld, 2021; Röllicke, 2023). While the former captures affect toward parties and political elites, the latter is directed at fellow voters, representing the most common understanding of the phenomenon.

As this study examines how political similarity shapes interpersonal evaluations, it concerns horizontal affective polarization. While this dimension is the primary focus of the literature, many studies are forced to operationalize affective polarization using feeling thermometers or like-dislike scales of political parties.⁵ As Röllicke (2023) notes, such measures capture vertical polarization rather than interpersonal affect between partisans. Although correlated (Harteveld, 2021), vertical polarization is an imperfect proxy for horizontal polarization, as individuals generally evaluate out-parties more negatively than out-partisans (e.g., Areal & Harteveld, 2024; Druckman & Levendusky, 2019; Kekkonen et al., 2022). By examining direct political matching, a recognized measure of affective polarization (Carlin & Love, 2025), this thesis helps address this measurement gap and contributes to the literature on horizontal affective polarization in multi-party settings.

2.2.1. Affective polarization in multi-party systems

Research on affective polarization originated in the U.S., but later studies show that the phenomenon is also widespread in other contexts (e.g., Reiljan, 2020; Wagner, 2021). However, moving from the American two-party system to multi-party settings introduces conceptual challenges, as it is no longer clear-cut which partisans constitute the in-group and the out-group (Wagner, 2021). First, although a strict conceptualization of partisanship implies exclusivity, individuals in multi-party systems often feel positive affect toward multiple parties (Garry, 2007), a tendency further compounded by a general decline in partisanship over recent decades, particularly in Europe (e.g., Wattenberg et al., 2002). Second, multi-party systems present individuals with several out-groups instead of one, and these are rarely disliked equally (Wagner, 2021). Against this background, Wagner (2021, p.

⁵ In the U.S., it is more common to measure affective polarization using trait ratings or social distance scales (Röllicke, 2023). The latter may, for example, involve asking respondents how they would feel about living next to, being friends with, or having their child marry an out-partisan (Iyengar & Wagner, 2025).

2) argues that “affective polarization in multiparty settings should be defined and assessed as the extent to which politics is seen as divided into two distinct camps”.

While this conceptualization operates at the aggregate level, a growing body of research has simultaneously sought to identify factors shaping partisan affect at the individual level in multi-party systems. Central to this literature is ideological distance.⁶ Research show that evaluations of out-partisans are negatively associated with how far apart parties are ideologically, even though affective and ideological polarization have traditionally been understood as distinct phenomena (Iyengar et al., 2012). Evidence of this pattern has been found across contexts, including the Netherlands (Harteveld, 2021), Belgium (Erkel & Turkenburg, 2022), Finland (Kekkonen & Ylä-Anttila, 2021), Spain (Viciano et al., 2019) and Sweden (Reiljan & Ryan, 2021). This relationship holds regardless of whether ideological distance is measured using objective measures, such as the Chapel Hill Expert Survey (CHES) (Harteveld, 2021), or subjective measures (e.g., Erkel & Turkenburg, 2022; Kekkonen & Ylä-Anttila, 2021). Gidron et al. (2023) and Harteveld (2021) further suggest that divides on socio-cultural issues generate stronger affect than economic disagreements.

Within this literature, however, scholars differ on how this relationship is structured. One strand models animosity toward out-party supporters as increasing linearly with ideological distance (Erkel & Turkenburg, 2022; Harteveld, 2021). Another suggests that affect is organized around broader *affective blocs* of ideologically similar parties, with the boundary between camps serving as the primary source of animosity. In this view, bloc membership functions as an identity in its own right, beyond party identification (Kekkonen & Ylä-Anttila, 2021; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021). Consistent with this, Bantel (2023) analyzes data from 23 Western democracies and finds that affect is more polarized between left and right-leaning party blocs than within them. Notably, these divides weaken when parties from opposing blocs govern together, suggesting that coalition membership shapes affective blocs beyond ideology alone. Similarly, Gidron et al. (2023) find that supporters of governing coalition parties view one another more favorably than their level of policy agreement would predict.

⁶ It should be noted that many studies in this literature measure affective polarization using dislike-like scales of parties, capturing vertical rather than horizontal affective polarization (see Section 2.2). As individuals generally evaluate out-parties more negatively than out-partisans, the observed effects may therefore be somewhat larger than if measures of affect toward partisans had been used (e.g., Areal & Harteveld, 2024; Druckman & Levendusky, 2019; Kekkonen et al., 2022).

Lastly, research points to an additional effect associated with populist radical right (PRR) parties,⁷ sometimes referred to as *radical right exceptionalism* (e.g., Gidron et al., 2023); supporters of these parties tend to express above-average animosity toward others, while also being more strongly disliked in return. Several studies find evidence for both patterns (Gidron et al., 2023; Harteveld, 2021; Harteveld et al., 2022), whereas others focus on the latter (Bantel, 2023; Bjånesøy, 2023; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021). Importantly, this negative affect exceeds what can be explained by ideological distance and affective blocs alone (Gidron et al., 2023; Harteveld, 2021). However, this mutual dislike does not appear to be fixed. Harteveld et al. (2022) show that electoral success reduces dislike toward PRR supporters, whereas government participation increases it, except among supporters of coalition partners.

Harteveld et al. (2022) trace this mutual animosity to the distinctive combination of populism and nativism characterizing PRR parties. Neither element alone is sufficient; the radical left shows no corresponding affective gap despite its populist elements (Bantel, 2023), and heightened animosity persists even when accounting for sociocultural polarization (Gidron et al., 2023; Harteveld, 2021). Rather, it appears to be the interaction between the two; Harteveld et al. (2022) highlight that a key feature of both ideologies is a shared tendency to favor an in-group ('the people' or 'the nation') while antagonizing an out-group ('the elite' or 'non-natives'). This fuels negative affect toward political opponents among PRR supporters, while their rhetoric simultaneously triggers a backlash from the broader electorate. In line with this, Gidron et al. (2023) argue that supporters of PRR parties are disliked not only for their policy positions but also for being perceived as promoting intolerance.

2.3. Hypotheses

Building on theory and empirical findings from prior research, I test four hypotheses regarding how political orientations influence romantic preferences. Because this study seeks to extend research on direct political matching to multi-party systems, I naturally conceptualize political homogamy in terms of party preferences. This choice is further motivated by the affective polarization literature underlying H2-H4, which centers on partisan

⁷ Following Mudde (2007, pp 11-31), populist radical right parties are defined by a core ideology comprising three elements: *nativism*, the belief that states should be inhabited exclusively by the native group and that non-native elements pose a fundamental threat; *authoritarianism*, the belief in a strictly ordered society with severe punishment for violations of authority; and *populism*, the view that society is divided into two antagonistic camps, "the pure people" versus "the corrupt elite", and that politics should reflect the general will of the people.

identities. That said, as noted in Sections 2.1.1 and 2.1.2, both homogamy and direct matching have been documented for other types of political orientations as well.

Following the literature on direct political matching, I expect that supporting the same party increases romantic interest in potential partners. Although this may not be the only mechanism underlying political homogamy, a broad range of evidence – from observational studies of established couples (e.g., Hudde & Grunow, 2025), analyses of online dating behavior (e.g., Huber & Malhotra, 2017) and experimental research (e.g., Easton & Holbein, 2021) – consistently points to its existence. The first hypothesis is therefore:

H1 (Same-party preference): *Individuals express greater romantic interest in potential partners when they support the same political party than when they support a different party.*

If this study were limited to a two-party system, as previous experimental studies (or the two largest parties, as in Sleiman et al., 2025), the preceding hypothesis would be sufficient. However, extending the analysis to multi-party contexts requires further theoretical elaboration. Given the limited literature on direct political matching in such settings, the following three hypotheses draw on research on affective polarization at the individual level (see Section 2.2.1). While H1 predicts a positive effect, the remaining hypotheses primarily concern variation in out-party evaluations and are therefore stated in a negative direction.

As noted in Section 2.1.1, there is a debate in the literature about whether out-party affect operates gradually and becomes more negative as ideological distance increases (Erkel & Turkenburg, 2022; Harteveld, 2021), or clusters into affective blocs shaped by ideological proximity, coalition dynamics, or both (Bantel, 2023; Gidron et al., 2023; Kekkonen et al., 2022; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021). Applying each logic to the context of direct political matching yields two distinct hypotheses:

H2 (Ideological distance): *Individuals express less romantic interest in potential romantic partners as the ideological distance between their respective parties increases, beyond the effects of affective blocs.*⁸

⁸ It should be noted that H1 and H2 partially overlap, since a partner from the same party has zero ideological distance, meaning H1 represents the extreme end of the continuum captured by H2. Despite this, H1 is stated as a separate hypothesis to facilitate comparisons with prior research in two-party systems.

H3 (Affective blocs): *Individuals express less romantic interest in potential partners when they support a party from an opposing affective party bloc than when they support a party from the same bloc, beyond the effects of ideological distance.*

These perspectives are not necessarily contradictory; romantic interest may decline gradually with ideological distance while out-bloc affiliation carries an additional penalty. To distinguish between them, the present study includes both variables in the same model, allowing each to be estimated while controlling for the other. Evidence for H2 requires a significant negative effect of ideological distance beyond bloc membership, while evidence for H3 requires a significant negative effect of out-bloc affiliation beyond ideological distance. This allows for the possibility that both mechanisms operate simultaneously, that only one of them holds, or that neither does.

Distinguishing between these two mechanisms has important implications for future levels of affective polarization. If bloc membership structures partner selection independently of ideological proximity, even individuals with modest political differences may avoid each other if they belong to different affective blocs. This would reinforce precisely the kind of bloc-based division that Wagner (2021) identifies as the defining feature of affective polarization in multi-party systems, and could further deepen these divides across generations through intergenerational transmission of political attitudes (Alford et al., 2011; Klofstad et al., 2013). By contrast, if ideological distance is the primary driver, the consequences for future levels of affective polarization are likely to be more limited.

Moreover, research suggests that supporters of PRR parties are disliked more strongly than ideological distance and bloc membership alone would suggest (e.g., Bantel, 2023; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021). If this pattern extends to romantic contexts, we should expect the following:

H4 (PRR penalty): *Individuals express less romantic interest in potential partners when they support a populist radical right party than when they do not, beyond the effects of ideological distance and affective blocs.*⁹

If PRR supporters face an additional penalty in partner selection, this could have further implications for affective polarization. Should mainstream voters systematically avoid PRR

⁹ While the literature also documents the reverse pattern, that PRR supporters themselves express greater animosity toward political out-groups (e.g., Gidron et al., 2023; Hartevelde, 2021), this cannot be examined in the present study due to the limited number of PRR supporters in the sample (17 participants).

supporters as romantic partners, this group may increasingly form relationships among themselves, resulting in politically homogeneous households. Through intergenerational transmission of attitudes (Alford et al., 2011; Klofstad et al., 2013), this could deepen affective divisions between PRR supporters and others even further over time.

3. Research design

3.1. Case selection

While the focus of this thesis is to examine direct political matching in multi-party contexts, the specific case under study is Sweden. The Swedish parliament (the *Riksdag*) consists of eight parties: the Left Party (V), the Green Party (MP), the Social Democrats (S), the Center Party (C), the Liberals (L), the Moderates (M), the Christian Democrats (KD) and the Sweden Democrats (SD). Following the most recent general election, held in 2022, a coalition of M, KD and L has governed, with parliamentary support from SD under the “Tidö agreement” (Tidöavtalet) (Aylott & Bolin, 2023). Ahead of the 2026 election, the governing parties have expressed willingness to include SD as a formal member of government should they remain in office (Palmborg & Hector, 2026). Meanwhile, the remaining four parties form a fragmented opposition (e.g., SVT Nyheter, 2025; 2026). These dynamics underpin the operationalization of affective blocs, described further in Section 3.3.1.

Although political homogamy in Sweden remains unstudied, data from the 2022 Swedish National Election Studies (SNES) indicate that respondents’ social networks tend to be politically homogenous (Olsson, 2024). Prior research also documents affective polarization among Swedish voters (Bäck et al., 2023; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021; Renström et al., 2020). While there are no comparative studies that directly measure horizontal affective polarization, research measuring vertical affective polarization typically places Sweden in the midrange (Reiljan, 2025; Wagner, 2021). Sweden thus constitutes a suitable case for extending research on direct political matching to multi-party systems. More specifically, its moderate levels of affective polarization reduce the risk of findings being driven by contextual extremes, strengthening the potential for generalization.¹⁰

¹⁰ It is worth noting that 2026 is an election year in Sweden. Prior research indicates that both partisanship (e.g., Michelitch & Utych, 2018) and affective polarization (e.g. Hernández et al., 2021) tend to intensify during election periods, which could inflate observed levels of direct political matching. However, as data were collected in March and April, well ahead of the September election and before the start of active campaigning, this risk is considered limited.

3.2. Experimental design

To test the hypotheses, I conducted a vignette survey experiment in which each respondent evaluated five profiles of hypothetical individuals, following the approach of prior experimental studies on direct political matching (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Nicholson et al., 2016).¹¹ This within-subject design strengthens causal identification by controlling for individual heterogeneity. More specifically, each respondent serves as their own reference, eliminating the need for a separate control group. It also increases the number of observations per respondent, enhancing statistical power and reducing the required sample size compared to a between-subjects design (Charness et al., 2012). The survey was conducted in Swedish using Qualtrics.

The choice of five profiles reflects a trade-off between ensuring sufficient within-person variation to achieve statistical power and maintaining data quality by limiting respondent fatigue and dropout risk. This situates the present study between more minimalist designs, such as Easton and Holbein (2021) and Nicholson et al. (2016), who presented only one profile per respondent, and more demanding designs, such as Huber and Malhotra (2017), who used ten profiles, and Sleiman et al. (2025), who used 16 sets with two profiles each.

The most central feature of the design is the manipulation of political affiliation, which constitutes the main treatment. Rather than full randomization, the party affiliation of the profiles was assigned conditional on the respondent's own party preference. Specifically, each of the five profiles presented to respondents corresponded to a distinct category of political similarity, summarized below in Table 1, and further operationalized in Section 3.3.2. To mitigate profile (or vignette) order effects, where ratings of earlier profiles influence subsequent ones (Auspurg & Hinz, 2015), the presentation order of profiles was randomized across respondents.

¹¹ An exception is Sleiman et al. (2025), who employ a conjoint experiment.

Table 1 Political affiliation of the profiles presented to respondents

Profile	Category	Example (S-respondent)
1	Same party	S
2	Non-peripheral party in the same bloc	MP/C
3*	Peripheral party in the same bloc	V
4	Non-peripheral party in the other bloc	L/M/KD
5	Peripheral party in the other bloc	SD

Note: Peripheral party is defined as a party on the ideological edge of the CHES overall left-right scale (see Section 3.3.2) *Profile 3 is not applicable for respondents who prefer the Left party (V) or the Sweden Democrats (SD), as there is no more ideologically peripheral party within their respective bloc. For these respondents, the political affiliation of profile 3 was randomized among the remaining non-peripheral parties in the same bloc that were not already assigned to profile 2.

The experimental design follows directly from the theoretical focus, and enables systematic testing of all four hypotheses. Specifically, profile 1 is used to test H1 (Same-party preference); variation in ideological distance and bloc membership across all profiles allows for tests of H2 (Ideological distance) and H3 (Affective blocs); and profiles at the ideological extremes (profile 3 or 5 depending on bloc membership) are used to test H4 (PRR penalty). The resulting estimates capture preferences relative to respondents' own party rather than unconditional party effects. This differs from previous studies that fully randomize party affiliation, but aligns with the relational nature of the research question.

Given the vignette design, in which the experimental treatment, i.e., profile party affiliation, was assigned conditional on the respondent's top-ranked party, standard balance checks across treatment groups are not applicable. Instead, the design is validated by verifying that profile assignments followed the intended structure (see Appendix A).

3.2.1. Profile construction

Each profile consisted of a brief description of a hypothetical individual. While previous studies have presented vignettes specifically as online dating profiles (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Sleiman et al., 2025), I adopt a broader framing for two reasons. First, the study seeks to capture partner preferences in a broad social context, not only in the specific behavioral setting of online dating platforms. Second, data from the 2024 National SOM Survey (University of Gothenburg, SOM Institute, 2026) indicate that only

11.6% of respondents (valid $n = 1,557$) met their current or most recent partner through a dating app or website, suggesting that a broader framing more accurately reflects how the majority of people in Sweden actually form relationships.

Figure 1 presents a translated example of a profile as shown to respondents. The vignettes contained information on name, age, height, education, and political affiliation. While the name was always positioned at the top, the order of the remaining attributes was randomized across vignettes. This was done to mitigate attribute order effects, where respondents assign greater weight to characteristics depending on their position (Kumar & Gaeth, 1991).¹²

Figure 1 **Example of a profile (translated from Swedish)**

Name: Emil Age: 24 years Height: 180 cm Education: Has university-level education Political affiliation: Votes for the Social democrats

Note: Each respondent evaluated five profiles, each varying in name, age, height, education, and political affiliation. While the name was always positioned at the top, the ordering of the remaining four attributes varied across vignettes.

As shown in Figure 1, the main attribute of interest, political affiliation, was presented as a voting behavior, e.g., “Votes for the Social Democrats”, rather than simply stating the party name. This framing both reflects the global trend toward partisan dealignment (Wattenberg et al., 2002), and ensures that the treatment isolates party affiliation without conflating it with strong partisan identity, party membership, or candidate status.

Respondents were directed to either male or female profiles based on their indicated sexual and/or romantic preferences,¹³ following the approach of prior studies (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Sleiman et al., 2025). Those attracted to both sexes, or who preferred not to specify,

¹² Within-respondent randomization of may increase unsystematic variation and cognitive demand. Randomize attribute order between respondents would have required a larger sample to balance all possible orderings (Kumar & Gaeth, 1991). Due to uncertainty about the final number of respondents, the former was chosen to ensure unbiased estimates regardless of sample size. Given that the profiles contained only five attributes and each respondent evaluated five profiles, the risk of fatigue was considered minimal.

¹³ The survey question was “Which persons are you romantically and/or sexually attracted to?” with response options “Men only”, “Women only”, “Both men and women”, and “Prefer not to specify”. Although this thesis primarily focuses on romantic attraction, sexual attraction was included to ensure inclusivity for respondents who may prioritize or exclusively experience sexual attraction.

were randomly assigned to one profile gender. This choice was made to maintain a consistent within-subject design by avoiding introducing gender as an additional source of variation.

Female profiles were assigned the names *Emma*, *Julia*, *Elin*, *Amanda*, and *Sara*, while male profiles were named *Alexander*, *Simon*, *Anton*, *Emil*, and *Erik*. Names were included to enhance realism. To ensure that the names were neutral and demographically representative, I obtained non-public data from the Swedish Tax Agency (Skatteverket, personal communication, February 27, 2026) on the most common names among Swedish citizens aged 18–35 (born 1991–2008). The top five names for each gender were included. Each respondent saw all names within the relevant set once, in random order.

The inclusion of age, height and education as profile attributes served a dual purpose. First, varying multiple attributes alongside political affiliation, reduces the risk of demand characteristics, that is, cues that may lead respondents to infer the study’s purpose and adjust their responses accordingly (Leustek, 2017).¹⁴ Second, it allows for an assessment of how respondents weigh political alignment relative to other desirable characteristics, directly addressing the research question. These attributes varied independently, and an “Evenly Present Elements” constraint ensured that every attribute level appeared with equal frequency across the total sample. The levels for each attribute are presented in Section 3.3.3.

In contrast to previous studies (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Nicholson et al., 2016; Sleiman et al., 2025), I deliberately excluded profile images. While their inclusion could have improved realism and external validity, images also introduce additional sources of variation, such as attractiveness, facial expression, ethnicity, and style, that are difficult to standardize and risk confounding the estimated effects. I therefore excluded images to prioritize experimental control and enable clear causal inference.

3.3. Operationalizations

3.3.1. Outcome variable

For each profile, respondents rated their romantic interest using two items introduced by the prompt “How interested would you be in” or, for respondents in a relationship, “If you were single, how interested would you be in”. The primary outcome variable used in the main analysis is interest in pursuing a romantic relationship, measured by the item “Pursuing a

¹⁴ Despite these efforts, the risk of demand characteristics remains a limitation of the study design; this issue is discussed in greater detail in Section 3.6.

romantic relationship with the person in this profile?”. This question was intended to capture the long-term partner preferences central to research on political homogamy. Similar measures have been employed in previous experimental research on direct political matching (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017), though with some variation in wording.

The outcome variable was measured on a five-point scale ranging from “Not interested at all” (1) to “Very interested” (5),¹⁵ with all points labeled to increase reliability and validity (see Krosnick & Berent, 1993). The literature typically recommends five to seven points (Krosnick & Fabrigar, 1997), and prior experimental studies vary in their implementation; Easton and Holbein (2021) and Nicholson et al. (2016) both use seven-point scales, while Huber and Malhotra (2017) use both four- and five-point scales. A five-point scale was chosen to reduce respondent burden and improve usability on mobile devices. Although the outcome variable was measured as an ordinal variable, it is treated as continuous in the analysis, following Huber and Malhotra (2017).

3.3.2. Political variables

Before the experimental component, respondents were asked to “Rank the eight parliamentary parties, from your best party to your worst party”.¹⁶ To minimize order effects, the order in which the parties were presented was randomized across respondents. The top-ranked party was used to condition the party affiliation of the profiles. To test H1 (Same-party preference), profile 1 is coded as a political match (see Table 1), resulting in a dummy variable coded 1 for same party and 0 otherwise. A ranking format was chosen in order to capture the full preference ordering across parties. Mean party placements are reported in Appendix B.

Ideological distance, the independent variable in H2, is operationalized as the absolute difference between the respondent’s top-ranked party and the party presented in the profile, based on expert placements from the 2024 Chapel Hill Expert Survey (CHES) (Rovny et al., 2025).¹⁷ This approach follows prior work on affective polarization at the individual level (Harteveld, 2021). Specifically, I use each party’s overall left-right ideological position,

¹⁵ The question wording and response scale were designed to be item-specific rather than based on an agree-disagree format, as this has been shown to reduce acquiescence bias, the tendency to respond positively regardless of question content (Stantcheva, 2023).

¹⁶ The terms “best party” (*bästa parti*) and “worst party” (*sämsta parti*) were chosen to align with the conventions of the Swedish National Election Studies (SNES) (Oscarsson et al., 2024) and the SOM Institute (University of Gothenburg, SOM Institute, 2026), which frame equivalent questions in the same way.

¹⁷ The 2024 wave of the CHES covers 279 parties in 31 European countries and was completed by 609 political scientists specializing in political parties and European integration.

measured on a scale from 0 (extremely left) to 10 (extremely right).¹⁸ Table 2 reports party placements ordered according to their relative left-right position.

Table 2 Overall left-right placement of Swedish parliamentary parties (CHES)

Party	V	MP	S	C	L	M	KD	SD
Chapel Hill Expert Survey (CHES)	1.6	2.7	3.7	5.9	6.7	7.6	8.0	8.5

Source: Chapel Hill Expert Survey 2024 (Rovny et al., 2025)

Note: Party abbreviations: the Left Party (V), the Green Party (MP), the Social Democrats (S), the Center Party (C), the Liberals (L), the Christian Democrats (KD), the Moderates (M), and the Sweden Democrats (SD). Ideological distance is calculated as the absolute difference between party scores.

While the literature on ideological distance and affective polarization suggests that results are robust across both objective and subjective measures (see Section 2.2.1), this study relies on objective placements only. The rationale for this was that including subjective measures (as done in e.g., Hartevelt, 2021; Kekkonen & Ylä-Anttila, 2021; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021), where respondents place themselves and each party on an ideological scale, was deemed likely to increase respondent burden and demand characteristics.¹⁹

To test H3 (Affective blocs), the parliamentary parties are grouped into a right-wing bloc (M, KD, L and SD) and a left-wing bloc (S, MP, V and C). In the analysis, I include a dummy variable representing out-bloc affiliation, coded as 1 if the profile belongs to the opposing affective bloc and 0 otherwise.

This operationalization reflects both the ideological placements of the parties (see Table 2) and contemporary coalition dynamics (see Section 3.1), in line with descriptions of affective blocs in the literature (e.g., Bantel, 2023; Gidron et al., 2023). Earlier research characterized the system as tripolar, with SD as an isolated outsider (Reiljan & Ryan, 2021). The Tidö agreement has, however, restructured the system into two affective blocs divided by willingness to cooperate with SD. The operationalization is further supported by respondents' own party rankings, which show that most respondents rated parties within their own bloc

¹⁸ The exact wording was “And finally, please tick the box that best describes each party's OVERALL IDEOLOGY on a scale ranging from 0 (extreme left) to 10 (extreme right).”

¹⁹ An alternative intermediate approach would have been to ask respondents only about their own ideological left-right placement and combine this with CHES-based party positions. While this would still not constitute a fully subjective measure, it could provide an indication of whether subjective and objective measures yield comparable results, functioning as a robustness check. Future research should consider this approach.

higher than parties in the opposing bloc (Appendix B). At the same time, any operationalization of affective blocs involves a degree of arbitrariness, and the classification used here is open to discussion, particularly given the considerable shifts in Swedish party coalitions in recent years (Aylott & Bolin, 2023).

Following the operationalization of ideological distance and affective blocs, Table 3 summarizes the party classification underlying the design (see Table 1). Each party is assigned to one of two affective blocs, and classified as either a non-peripheral party or the ideologically peripheral party within that bloc. For instance, a respondent who ranks S first would see MP or C in profile 2 (Non-peripheral party in the same bloc) and V in profile 3 (Peripheral party in the same bloc).

Table 3 Party classification by affective bloc and ideological position

	Non-peripheral party	Peripheral party
Right-wing bloc	Christian Democrats (KD), Liberals (L), Moderates (M)	Sweden Democrats (SD)
Left-wing bloc	Center Party (C), Green Party (MP), Social Democrats (S)	Left Party (V)

Note: The classification of parties into affective blocs reflects both their ideological placements and the contemporary parliamentary situation. SD and V are classified as the ideologically peripheral parties of their respective blocs based on their positions on the CHES overall left-right scale (see Table 2).

Finally, to test H4 (PRR penalty), the Sweden Democrats (SD) are operationalized as a PRR party, following Mudde's (2007) definition (see footnote 7) and explicit classification of European PRR parties, which includes SD (p.307). This is reflected in a dummy variable coded 1 for SD profiles and 0 for other profiles. For respondents who rank SD at the top, all profiles are coded as 0, as no penalty is expected among PRR supporters themselves.

Importantly, the coefficient for this dummy variable should be interpreted differently depending on bloc membership. For left-bloc respondents, it is expected to capture an additional negative effect beyond out-bloc affiliation. For right-bloc respondents, it identifies whether SD supporters are evaluated differently from other right-bloc supporters, controlling for ideological distance.

Lastly, it should be noted that the three independent variables are moderately correlated, which is expected given their construction. A correlation matrix is reported in Appendix B.

3.3.3. Nonpolitical profile attributes

In addition to political affiliation, each profile varied in name, age difference, height, and education. The selection of names is described in Section 3.2.1, while remaining three attributes are described below and summarized in Table 4. These attributes were selected based on their established importance in partner selection (see Buss & Schmitt, 2019). As they primarily serve to enhance realism and provide benchmarks for interpreting the magnitude of the political effects, this section describes only the levels used. A theoretical background for each attribute and an analysis of their effects is provided in Appendix F.

First, age varied across three levels relative to the respondent: same age, two years younger, and two years older. Among previous experimental studies on direct political matching, only Huber and Malhotra (2017) vary age, though using fixed categories. The respondent-relative approach adopted here better aligns with research on partner preferences, which points to the existence of age homogamy (Feng & Baker, 1994; Watson et al., 2004)

Second, the height of the profiles varied across three levels: tall, average, and short, with gender-specific values (see Table 4). Previous studies also include height, though only as a binary distinction between tall and short (Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Sleiman et al., 2025). In this study, average height for each gender is based on Swedish population data (Statistics Sweden, 2018)²⁰, with tall and short operationalized as 10 cm above and below this average.

Finally, education varied across two levels: upper secondary education and university education.²¹ Previous studies have also included education, using two (Sleiman et al., 2025) or three levels (Huber & Malhotra, 2017). I adopt a binary operationalization for two reasons. First, including compulsory schooling as a lower level would be unrepresentative, as the vast majority in the target age group (18-35) in Sweden have completed upper secondary

²⁰ The most recent available data on average height in Sweden date to 2016-2017. However, given that the average height increased by only 2 cm between the early 1980s and then, the figures are unlikely to have changed substantially since (Statistics Sweden, 2018).

²¹ In the original Swedish survey, the categories were labeled *gymnasieutbildning* and *universitetsutbildning*. Upper secondary education in Sweden (*gymnasieutbildning*) is a three-year program typically attended by students aged 16-19, following compulsory schooling. University education (*universitetsutbildning*) refers to tertiary education at universities or university colleges, including both undergraduate and graduate studies.

education.²² Second, finer distinctions within university education would yield unrealistic profiles for the youngest respondents. Still, a limitation arising from the joint variation of age and education remains and is discussed in Section 3.6.

Table 4 **Attribute levels for vignette profiles (by gender when applicable)**

Attribute	Levels	Male profile	Female profile
Age difference	Same age		
	2 years younger		
	2 years older		
Height	Tall	190 cm	176 cm
	Average	180 cm	166 cm
	Short	170 cm	156 cm
Education	Upper secondary education		
	University education		

Note: In the profiles, age is conditioned on the respondent's own age. Average height is based on Swedish population data (Statistics Sweden, 2018), with tall and short defined as 10 cm above and below this average.

3.3.4. Other variables

The survey also included sociodemographic questions on gender, age, residential area, education level, and marital status. These variables were collected in order to describe the sociodemographic characteristics of the sample (see Section 3.5), and enable heterogeneity analyses (see Appendix E). In addition, respondents' age was used to condition the age of the profiles (see Section 3.3.3). The wording of these questions is based on either the SOM survey or SNES (see Appendix H for the full instrument).

3.4. Survey flow

The survey opened with a landing page that provided a brief and general description of the study's purpose and the estimated completion time, following Stantcheva (2023). This was followed by information on data processing in accordance with the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), including the types of personal data collected and the voluntary nature of participation. Respondents were informed that proceeding with the survey constituted

²² According to Statistics Sweden (2024) only 8% of 25–34-year-olds in Sweden have not completed upper secondary school.

informed consent, but that they retained the right to withdraw at any time, in accordance with the ethical guidelines of The Swedish Research Council (Åkerman, 2024).

Following the introduction, the questionnaire began with sociodemographic questions (see Section 3.3.4) and an attention check (see Footnote 23), followed by questions on political characteristics (see Section 3.3.1). Respondents were then given instructions for the experimental component, and asked to indicate their romantic and/or sexual preferences, before proceeding to the vignettes. The survey closed with a debriefing about the full purpose of the study, an opportunity to provide feedback, and an encouragement to share the survey with others via a copyable link. The full survey instrument is presented in Appendix H.

3.5. Sample and data collection

The target population is Swedish residents aged 18-35 years, reflecting the age group most likely to be actively seeking romantic partners. This is consistent with previous experimental studies on direct political matching; Huber & Malhotra (2017) use the same range, while Sleiman et al. (2025) include respondents aged 18-40. Respondents outside the target age range were not excluded from completing the survey but are omitted from the main analysis. Both respondents in and outside romantic relationships were included.

The data was collected between March 27th and April 19th. I recruited respondents using a combination of convenience and snowball sampling, both forms of non-probability sampling (Stantcheva, 2023). To recruit participants, I designed a poster with a QR code (see Appendix G), which was distributed across university buildings, public libraries, public bulletin boards, cafes, and bars, primarily in Gothenburg. In addition, a digital version was shared via Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, and LinkedIn. Several of my contacts on these platforms subsequently reshared the post.

In total, 828 individuals accessed the survey, of whom 587 (70.9%) completed all questions, passed the attention check,²³ and fell within the target age range (18-35 years), forming the final sample. As each respondent evaluated five profiles, the data comprises 2,935 observations. Table 5 reports the sociodemographic characteristics of the sample. These are

²³ The attention check took the form of an instructional manipulation check (Oppenheimer et al., 2009) in which respondents were instructed to select a specific response option (“For this question, please select the response option “Strongly disagree”) Its purpose was to identify and exclude inattentive respondents. The item was not explicitly labeled or described as an attention check to avoid potential respondent reactance, and it consisted solely of this instruction to avoid contradictory instructions.

compared to population statistics in Appendix B. Overall, women, highly educated respondents, and individuals living in large cities are overrepresented.

Table 5 Sociodemographic characteristics of the sample

Variable	Category	n	%
Gender	Women	405	69.0
	Men	173	29.5
	Other/Prefer not to specify	9	1.5
Age group	18–24 years	330	56.2
	25–29 years	198	33.7
	30–35 years	59	10.1
Education	Low	57	9.7
	Medium	229	39.0
	High	301	51.3
Residential area	Large city	455	77.5
	City or larger town	95	16.2
	Small town or countryside	37	6.3
Marital status	Single	278	47.4
	In a relationship	118	20.1
	Cohabiting	164	27.9
	Married / Registered partnership	27	4.6
Romantic/sexual attraction	Only men	314	53.5
	Only women	172	29.3
	Both men and women	97	16.5
	Prefer not to specify	4	0.7

Note: N = 587. Percentages may not sum to 100 due to rounding. Education is measured as highest completed or currently ongoing level: low = primary and upper secondary school, medium = tertiary education, not college/university and college/university, 3 years or less, high = college/university, longer than 3 years, and postgraduate education. Residential area is based on respondents' self-reported place of residence. "Large city" refers to is Gothenburg, Stockholm, and Malmö, and "Small town or countryside combines two originally separate response options. See Appendix H. for the survey instrument.

Table 6 presents the political characteristics of the sample. Appendix B compares the distribution of top-ranked parties to the 2024 SOM Survey, poll-of-polls averages, and the 2022 election results, as well as partisan strength to the 2024 SOM Survey. Compared to 18-35-year-olds in the 2024 SOM Survey, the left bloc, and especially the Left Party (V), is overrepresented, while the right bloc, and particularly the Sweden Democrats (SD) is underrepresented. The implications of these discrepancies, regarding both sociodemographic and political characteristics, are discussed further in Section 3.7.

Table 6 Political characteristics of the sample

Variable	Category	n	%
Top-ranked political party	Left Party (V)	171	29.1
	Green Party (MP)	89	15.2
	Social Democrats (S)	167	28.4
	Center Party (C)	43	7.3
	Liberals (L)	21	3.6
	Moderates (M)	71	12.1
	Christian Democrats (KD)	8	1.4
	Sweden Democrats (SD)	17	2.9
Partisanship	Strong partisan	100	17.0
	Weak partisan	271	46.2
	Non-partisan	216	36.8

Note: N = 587. Percentages may not sum to 100 due to rounding. Partisanship is measured as strength of support for the top-ranked party: strong partisan = “Yes very convinced”, weak partisan = “Yes somewhat convinced”, non-partisan = “No”. See Appendix H. for the survey instrument.

3.6. Limitations

Naturally, this study is subject to certain limitations, some of which are addressed in the robustness and heterogeneity tests (Sections 4.2 and 4.3). First the sample deviates from the target population in several ways. More specifically, women, highly educated individuals, residents of major cities and left-bloc supporters are overrepresented (see Appendix B). These discrepancies are expected given the non-probability sampling strategy but may limit the generalizability of the findings. There is no clear consensus in the literature that direct political matching differs systematically by gender, education, residential area, or political orientation. While Sleiman et al. (2025) find stronger effects among left-wing and female respondents, the overall patterns tend to be consistent across subgroups. Future research should nonetheless replicate these findings using probability-based samples.

A further limitation concerns the joint variation of age and education. For the youngest respondents, particularly 18 and 19-year-olds, profiles two years younger are 16 or 17 years old, which combined with university-level education produces unrealistic profiles, as Swedish students typically do not begin university education before age 18. Such impossible attribute combinations are a recognized concern in survey experiments, and while they do not threaten internal validity, they may reduce external validity (Hainmueller et al., 2014). At the same

time, prior research suggests that unrealistic attribute combinations have limited effects on response behavior (Bansak & Jenke, 2025).

Moreover, the experimental setting raises concerns about external validity. In reality, political affiliation is rarely disclosed at the outset of a romantic encounter. Even in online dating contexts, research suggests that users rarely express explicit political views (Hitsch et al., 2010; Klofstad et al., 2012). Relatedly, real-world partner evaluation involves a much richer set of cues that are not captured here, such as personality, appearance, and interests. Together, this may lead the design to overestimate the importance of political similarity in partner selection. However, these limitations are shared with prior experimental studies (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Nicholson et al., 2016; Sleiman et al., 2025). Moreover, this approach remains valuable for isolating the causal effect of political similarity through counterfactual comparisons, which is not feasible in observational designs.

A related concern is the risk of demand characteristics and social desirability bias. The design required measuring respondents' party preference before the experimental component. This may have made the study's focus more apparent, leading respondents to place greater weight on political affiliation than they otherwise would. To mitigate this, profiles included multiple other varying attributes, and neither the landing page nor the recruitment materials disclosed the full purpose of the study.²⁴ Nonetheless, this risk cannot be fully eliminated. Meanwhile, social desirability bias, the tendency of respondents to present a favorable image of themselves rather than reveal their true attitudes, may operate in the opposite direction, with respondents potentially underreporting disinterest based on political affiliation. The anonymous online format mitigates this to some extent (Stantcheva, 2023)

3.7. Method

The data is analyzed in Stata using fixed effects Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regressions. Respondent-level fixed effects remove between-person variation, controlling for unobserved individual heterogeneity and restricting estimation to within-person comparisons (Huntington-Klein, 2022). Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level to account for correlated error terms across the five observations per respondent, which is appropriate given the likely heterogeneity in treatment effects and the non-probability sampling (Abadie et al., 2023).

²⁴ A potential exception applies to respondents who know me personally, as awareness of my academic background in political science may have allowed them to infer the study's purpose.

Four models are estimated. Model 1 includes a dummy for same-party preference to test H1, while Models 2-4 exclude this variable. This is because H1 and H2 partially overlap, as profiles from the same party have zero ideological distance. Moreover, H1 primarily serves to replicate previous studies, while H2-H4 constitute the main contribution of this study. Model 2 includes only ideological distance to establish a baseline, while Model 3 adds out-bloc affiliation to jointly test H2 and H3. Model 4 introduces the PRR variable to test H4. All four models include dummy variables for age difference, height, and education to improve estimation precision and to examine the effects of these additional attributes.²⁵

4. Results

The following section presents the results of the study, organized into three parts: the main analysis, robustness tests, and heterogeneity analyses. Appendix A verifies that the profile party affiliation assignments followed the intended structure.

4.1. Main analysis

The regression results of all four models are presented in Table 7. The average level of relationship interest across all respondents and profiles is 2.7 (SD = 1.3). More descriptive statistics are reported in Appendix B. To facilitate comparability with previous studies, Appendix C reports the main analysis with a standardized outcome variable. The main text reports unstandardized results to facilitate substantive interpretation of the findings.

²⁵ Profile names are excluded from the models as they serve only to enhance the realism of the profiles and carry no theoretical relevance.

Table 7 Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.124*** (0.041)			
Ideological distance		-0.342*** (0.009)	-0.274*** (0.015)	-0.235*** (0.015)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.374*** (0.069)	-0.271*** (0.065)
PRR affiliation				-0.708*** (0.049)
2 years younger	-0.318*** (0.059)	-0.328*** (0.049)	-0.332*** (0.048)	-0.333*** (0.046)
2 years older	-0.036 (0.057)	-0.057 (0.047)	-0.053 (0.046)	-0.063 (0.044)
Short	-0.262*** (0.059)	-0.235*** (0.047)	-0.241*** (0.046)	-0.264*** (0.044)
Tall	0.079 (0.061)	0.106* (0.052)	0.099 (0.051)	0.082 (0.049)
University education	0.235*** (0.050)	0.228*** (0.041)	0.229*** (0.041)	0.228*** (0.039)
Observations	2935	2935	2935	2935
Within R ²	0.190	0.465	0.474	0.521

Note: Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Ideological distance is measured as the absolute difference between the respondent's top-ranked party and profile party placement on the CHES overall left-right scale. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level.. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Model 1 indicates that profiles from the same party are on average rated 1.12 points higher on the five-point relationship interest scale compared to profiles from other parties, controlling for all other attributes. This effect is statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), providing support for H1 (Same-party preference). The coefficient is substantively large, corresponding to roughly one fifth of the full response scale and exceeding all other attribute effects in the model. To put it into perspective, the second largest effect is observed for profiles two years younger, which are associated with a penalty of 0.32 points.

Turning to the standardized results in Appendix C, co-partisan profiles are associated with an increase of 0.86 standard deviations in relationship interest. This effect is larger than the 0.41 standard deviations reported by Easton and Holbein (2021) when pooling their five

experiments, and considerably larger than the 0.01-0.09 range found by Huber and Malhotra (2017), depending on the outcome measure. However, it is smaller than the 1.05 standard deviations reported by Nicholson et al. (2016). Overall, the effect size falls within the range established by previous research, albeit toward the higher end. That said, these studies differ in both the operationalization of political orientation (see Section 2.1.2) and the outcomes used, which means comparisons should be made with some caution.

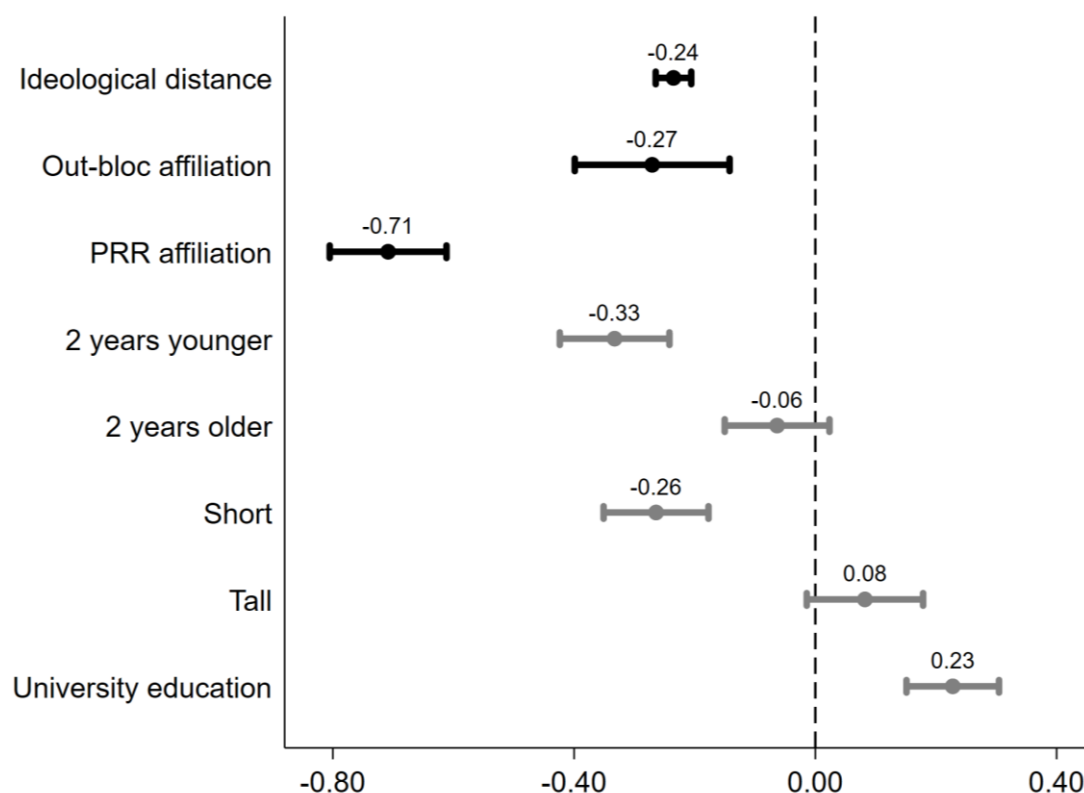
Moving beyond this binary divide, Model 2 shows a negative association between ideological distance and relationship interest. For each additional point on the ten-point CHES left-right scale, interest decreases by 0.34 points. This effect is statistically significant ($p < 0.001$). In Model 3, the coefficient for ideological distance decreases slightly to 0.27, which is expected given the correlation between the two variables. Still, it remains statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), providing support for H2 (Ideological distance). Beyond this effect, Model 3 shows that out-bloc affiliation is associated with a 0.37 points decrease in romantic interest. This effect is statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), and provides support for H3 (Affective blocs). Taken together, this means that within the same affective bloc, each additional point of ideological distance reduces interest by 0.27 points, while out-bloc affiliation adds an additional negative effect of 0.37 points.

In Model 4, the effects of ideological distance and out-bloc affiliation remain negative and statistically significant, although both decrease slightly, which is expected given their correlation with PRR affiliation. The negative effect of ideological distance drops from 0.27 to 0.24, while the penalty for out-bloc affiliation decreases more substantially, from 0.37 to 0.27. Controlling for these factors, SD profiles are rated 0.71 points lower than profiles from other parties. This effect is statistically significant ($p < 0.001$) and supports H4 (PRR penalty). As discussed in Section 3.3.2, the PRR coefficient should be interpreted with bloc membership in mind. For left-bloc respondents, both the out-bloc and PRR effects apply to SD profiles. Among right-bloc respondents, this coefficient suggests that SD supporters are evaluated more negatively than other in-bloc profiles.

Turning to the explanatory power of the models, the within R^2 increases across specifications, from 0.19 in Model 1 to 0.52 in Model 4, indicating that the most comprehensive model explains about half of the within-respondent variation in relationship interest. The largest increase occurs between Model 1 and Model 2, from 0.19 to 0.47, while additional gains in Models 3 and 4 are more modest.

To facilitate comparison across profile attributes, Figure 2 visualizes the coefficient estimates from Model 4. As ideological distance is a continuous variable, its coefficient is not directly comparable to those of the remaining dummy variables. The estimated effect on relationship interest is obtained by multiplying the coefficient by the number of scale steps between the respondent's top-ranked party and the party in the profile. Among the other variables, however, PRR affiliation is associated with the largest negative effect (-0.71). The effect of out-bloc affiliation is smaller (-0.27), and of comparable magnitude to the penalties associated with younger profiles (-0.33) and short profiles (-0.26). University education is the only attribute with a statistically significant positive effect (0.23). Note that the effects of the nonpolitical attributes are further discussed in Appendix F.

Figure 2 Coefficient estimates from Model 4 (95% confidence intervals)



Note: The figure presents coefficient estimates from Model 4 with 95% confidence intervals. Respondent fixed effects are included, and standard errors are clustered at the respondent level. The estimates for age difference, height and education are relative to their respective reference categories (same age, average height, and upper secondary education). The dashed vertical line indicates no effect.

Lastly, to illustrate how the political effects accumulate, imagine a Social Democrat (S) respondent evaluating profiles from three different parties. First, a Green Party (MP) profile is ideologically close to S on the 0-10 CHES overall left-right scale (1.0 scale steps; see Table

2) resulting in a predicted reduction in relationship interest by 0.24 points. Note that this does not correspond to an actual step on the five-point scale, but follows from the model treating the outcome as a continuous variable. Next, a Liberal (L) profile is more ideologically distant (3.0 scale steps), and additionally belongs to the out-bloc, resulting in a total reduction of 0.99 points ($0.24 \times 3.0 + 0.27$). Finally, a Sweden Democrat (SD) profile accumulates the effects of ideological distance (4.8 scale steps), out-bloc affiliation, and PRR affiliation, resulting in a total reduction of 2.13 points ($0.24 \times 4.8 + 0.27 + 0.71$). This example illustrates how the three political effects in Model 4 combine, offering a more nuanced picture of direct political matching than the binary logic in Model 1.

4.2. Robustness tests

To assess the sensitivity of the main findings, several robustness tests were conducted, all reported in Appendix D. First, the analysis was replicated using date interest as the outcome variable instead of relationship interest (Table D1). The results are largely consistent with the main analysis, with only minor differences in coefficient magnitudes, suggesting that the findings are robust to the choice of outcome variable.

Second, I replicate the main analysis using two alternative CHES measures of ideological distance: economic left-right and GAL-TAN placements (Rovny et al., 2025) (Tables D3-D4). The results show that the findings are not sensitive to the choice of ideological measure. However, in line with prior research on affective polarization (Gidron et al., 2023; Harteveld, 2021), the GAL-TAN measure produces somewhat stronger effects in Model 2, suggesting that socio-cultural divides may be more central to partner preferences than economic ones.

Third, the main analysis is replicated using mean voter-perceived left-right placements from the 2022 SNES (Oscarsson et al. 2024) (Table D5). The findings are largely robust, though out-bloc affiliation loses statistical significance in Model 4. This may reflect that voter-perceived ideological positions overlap more strongly with affective bloc divisions than the expert-based placements (see Appendix D for more).

Fourth, I replicate the main analysis excluding respondents aged 18 and 19 (Table D6) to address the impossible attribute combinations discussed in Section 3.6. The results remain largely consistent with the main analysis, suggesting that the findings are robust to the inclusion of these respondents.

Finally, the last robustness test adds a dummy variable for Left Party (V) profiles alongside the PRR dummy in Model 4, to assess whether the observed PRR penalty reflects something specific to these parties or a more general dislike of ideological extremity (Table D7). The coefficient for the added variable is positive and only marginally significant ($p < 0.05$), providing further support for H4.

Overall, the robustness tests support the main findings. The results are largely stable across alternative outcome measures, different operationalizations of ideological distance, sample restrictions, and the PRR-specificity test.

4.3. Heterogeneity tests

To assess heterogeneity in the main effects, the analysis is replicated separately by affective bloc membership, partisan identity, gender, and relationship status. The full results are reported in Appendix E, with the key findings summarized below.

The heterogeneity analyses by affective bloc membership reveal some notable differences (Tables E1-E2). The same-party effect is somewhat larger among left-bloc respondents, consistent with Sleiman et al. (2025). In Model 4, the effect of ideological distance is also stronger among left-bloc respondents, while the PRR coefficient is more pronounced among right-bloc respondents. Most notably, the out-bloc coefficient is statistically insignificant among right-bloc respondents. The model also fits considerably better for left-bloc respondents, as reflected in the higher within R^2 across all four models.

The heterogeneity analyses by partisan identity (Tables E3-E4) show that most effects are stronger among partisans, consistent with prior research on both affective polarization and direct political matching (Reiljan & Ryan, 2021; Sleiman et al., 2025). The only exception to this overall pattern concerns PRR affiliation, which has a stronger negative effect among non-partisans. The within R^2 is also higher among partisans across all models. Among non-partisans, the effect of out-bloc affiliation loses statistical significance in Model 4.

The heterogeneity analyses by gender (Tables E5-E6) show that the same-party effect is stronger among women, in line with (Nicholson et al., 2016; Sleiman et al., 2025). The within R^2 is also somewhat higher for female respondents. The most notable difference, however, concerns the out-bloc coefficient in Model 4, which is statistically significant among women but not among men. While this pattern mirrors the difference between left- and right-bloc

respondents, gender and affective bloc membership are only modestly correlated in the sample ($r = 0.12$), suggesting these are largely independent effects.

Lastly, the heterogeneity analyses by relationship status (Tables E7-E8) show strikingly similar results across single and partnered respondents in both effect sizes and model fit. The only notable difference is that the out-bloc coefficient reaches only marginal significance ($p < 0.05$) in Model 4 among respondents in a relationship. Overall, relationship status does not appear to moderate the effects of direct political matching.

The heterogeneity analyses indicate that while effect sizes vary across subgroups, the main effects are broadly consistent in direction and statistical significance. The effect of out-bloc affiliation is, however, not significant across all subgroups, suggesting that it may be more conditional than the other effects. At the same time, some subgroups are small, which limits the precision of the estimates and warrants caution in their interpretation.

5. Concluding discussion

This thesis asks: do political opposites attract? To address this question, and more specifically, to examine the extent to which political (dis)similarity shapes romantic interest in a multi-party system, I conducted a within-subject vignette survey experiment in Sweden. Respondents evaluated five hypothetical dating profiles, each varying in political party affiliation and nonpolitical attributes. The party affiliations of the profiles were assigned so that each respondent was exposed to five distinct categories of parties, creating the basis for examining several dimensions of political matching. The findings provide support for all four proposed hypotheses. In line with previous experimental research (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Nicholson et al., 2016; Sleiman et al., 2025), respondents evaluate co-partisans more favorably than supporters of other parties, controlling for all other profile attributes. Importantly, this study further shows that romantic interest decreases with ideological distance, while profiles from the opposing affective bloc and PRR profiles are associated with additional negative effects, net of ideological distance and each other.

These results contribute to the literature on political homogamy and direct political matching by extending this line of research to multi-party contexts. As noted in the theoretical background, previous experimental studies have been limited to two-party systems (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Nicholson et al., 2016) or focused solely on the two major parties (Sleiman et al., 2025). Therefore, direct political matching has generally been

understood as a binary preference for co-partisans over out-partisans. However, this study shows that such an understanding is too simplistic in multi-party systems, where individuals instead differentiate between different groups of out-partisans when evaluating potential partners. This is reflected, among other things, in the substantial increase in explanatory power when moving from a binary logic to a more complex understanding of direct political matching (Model 1 to Model 4). The fact that all three additional hypotheses hold further demonstrates that this differentiation cannot be reduced to a single explanation, such as ideological distance, but that multiple dimensions shape romantic interest simultaneously.

Additionally, this study contributes to research on affective polarization in two ways. First, by examining direct political matching, which is often treated as a behavioral manifestation of horizontal affective polarization (Carlin & Love, 2025), this thesis helps address the lack of direct measures of this phenomenon in the literature. Furthermore, by drawing on the affective polarization research to develop hypotheses, this study shows that the logic underlying general evaluations of out-partisans may extend to romantic contexts. At the same time, these contributions should be interpreted with some caution. The mechanisms driving the observed patterns of evaluations are not tested directly, meaning that affective polarization cannot be confirmed as the underlying cause. For example, less favorable evaluations of PRR-affiliated profiles may not necessarily stem from animosity toward these partisans. Instead, party affiliation may serve as a cue for other characteristics (Rothschild et al., 2019), or respondents may anticipate that a relationship with a politically dissimilar partner would involve conflict (Gerber et al., 2012; Graham et al., 2009).

Beyond their scientific relevance, the findings of this study have broader societal implications. First, they provide evidence that political party affiliation structures our social environment and affects our daily lives. Whether or not this can be attributed to affective polarization, political orientations function as a lens through which we evaluate others. Importantly, this appears to go beyond mere policy disagreements, as affective bloc membership and PRR affiliation shape evaluations independently of ideological distance. This alone can be seen as normatively concerning. Beyond this, however, direct political matching may also reinforce affective polarization over time and push more individuals toward the ideological extremes through the intergenerational transmission of political attitudes (Alford et al., 2011; Klostad et al., 2013). For example, if the penalty observed here leads PRR supporters to primarily partner among themselves and have children with similar views, this could deepen divides between them and other voters. Although somewhat debated

(e.g., Broockman et al., 2023; Voelkel et al., 2023), such dynamics could eventually have broader democratic consequences, including democratic backsliding (Orhan, 2022), political violence (Berntzen, 2025), and reduced political accountability (Sulmont & Incio, 2025).

The findings also take on relevance in the context of growing gender differences in political orientations. As mentioned in the introduction of this thesis, research consistently shows that women in Western democracies are more likely to support left-wing parties, while men more often support right-wing parties (Abendschön & Steinmetz, 2014; Shorrocks, 2021). In Sweden, this modern gender gap (Inglehart & Norris, 2000) reached a historic high in the most recent election. It was also most pronounced among young voters, suggesting these differences may increase even further in the future (Ahlbom & Karlsson, 2023). If political preferences structure partner choice in the ways suggested by the findings of this study, growing gender differences in party preferences could make heterosexual couple formation more difficult over time. More specifically, as men and women become more politically divided, individuals may increasingly encounter potential partners with differing political views, which this study finds is associated with lower romantic interest. This could in turn have broader, albeit speculative, consequences for demographic patterns such as fertility rates.

At the same time, these implications should be considered in light of several limitations. First, although the experimental design offers high internal validity, this comes at the expense of reduced external validity. This study relies on a hypothetical setting, and it remains uncertain whether partner selection operates in the same way in real life. Because respondents had relatively few attributes to base their evaluations on, party affiliation may have been given greater weight than it would in real-world contexts. There is also a risk that respondents inferred the purpose of the study and adjusted their responses accordingly. That said, the observed patterns are unlikely to differ entirely from real-world partner evaluations. The significant effects of nonpolitical attributes further suggest that respondents did not rely solely on political cues. Another limitation concerns the sample, which is not fully representative of the broader population. While most findings are consistent across subgroups in the heterogeneity analyses, the out-bloc effect (H3) does not hold for male respondents, right-bloc respondents, or those without a partisan identity. This effect should therefore be interpreted with some caution in these subgroups.

Building on these and other limitations, several avenues for future research emerge. First, the study should be replicated with a more representative probability sample. Future studies should also examine whether the effects hold when respondents have more attributes to base

their evaluations on. Relatedly, the inclusion of more attributes could help test the underlying mechanisms. For example, to examine whether it is party affiliation per se that drives lower romantic interest in out-partisans, or whether it is used as a cue for other characteristics, Sleiman et al. (2025) create what they call “counter-stereotypical profiles”. While this approach was considered beyond the scope of the present study, as it would have required substantially more preparatory work when working with eight parties instead of two, it represents a promising direction for future research. Furthermore, qualitative research could serve as a complement in exploring the underlying mechanisms of direct political matching in multi-party systems. Interview studies could, for example, shed further light on how, why, and when individuals take political similarity into consideration in partner selection.

Moreover, future studies should move beyond the Swedish context and examine whether these findings hold in other multi-party systems. Inevitably, some of the results may be context specific. The risk of non-replication is likely highest for the out-bloc effect (H3), and the PRR effect (H4). The logic of affective blocs is likely to differ across political systems. Even within the Swedish context, the operationalization used in this study is open to discussion, given that party coalitions have shifted considerably over the past decade (Aylott & Bolin, 2023). Regarding PRR affiliation, the affective polarization literature (Harteveld et al., 2022) shows that electoral success reduces dislike toward PRR supporters, while government participation increases it. This suggests that the effect of PRR affiliation on romantic interest may be different in contexts where these parties have reached another level of electoral support, or where they participate in government. Nevertheless, this study represents an important first step toward understanding how political party affiliations shape romantic partner preferences in multi-party contexts.

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AI declaration

The author acknowledges the use of AI-based tools (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Ecosia AI search) in the writing process of this thesis. This included language editing, grammar correction as well as improving the clarity and structure of the text. The tools were also used as a discussion partner during the development of the research design, for assistance with coding and troubleshooting in Stata, and to support the understanding of the statistical outputs. No part of the AI-generated output was directly incorporated into the thesis. All final methodological decisions, data analysis and substantive interpretations were conducted independently by the author, who takes full responsibility for the content of this thesis.

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Appendix A. Experimental design

Table A1 Complete profile assignment scheme by top-ranked party

Top-ranked party	Profile 1	Profile 2	Profile 3	Profile 4	Profile 5
V	V	MP/S/C	MP/S/C*	L/KD/M	SD
MP	MP	S/C	V	L/KD/M	SD
S	S	MP/C	V	L/KD/M	SD
C	C	MP/S	V	L/KD/M	SD
L	L	KD/M	SD	MP/S/C	V
M	M	L/KD	SD	MP/S/C	V
KD	KD	L/M	SD	MP/S/C	V
SD	SD	L/KD/M	L/KD/M *	MP/S/C	V

Note: Party abbreviations: the Left Party (V), the Green Party (MP), the Social Democrats (S), the Center Party (C), the Liberals (L), the Moderates (M), the Christian Democrats (KD), and the Sweden Democrats (SD).

*For respondents who prefer the Left party (V) or the Sweden Democrats (SD), the political affiliation of profile 3 was randomized among the remaining mainstream parties in the same bloc that were not already assigned to profile 2.

Table A2 Experimental design check: Assignment of profile party affiliation by top-ranked party

	V	MP	S	C	L	M	KD	SD
V	100,0 (171)	66,7 (114)	65,5 (112)	67,8 (116)	32,7 (56)	33,3 (57)	33,9 (58)	100,0 (171)
MP	100,0 (89)	100,0 (89)	48,3 (43)	51,7 (46)	31,5 (28)	33,7 (30)	34,8 (31)	100,0 (89)
S	100,0 (167)	48,5 (81)	100,0 (167)	51,5 (86)	34,1 (57)	33,5 (56)	32,3 (54)	100,0 (167)
C	100,0 (43)	48,8 (21)	51,2 (22)	100,0 (43)	32,6 (14)	30,2 (13)	37,2 (16)	100,0 (43)
L	100,0 (21)	23,8 (5)	38,1 (8)	38,1 (8)	100,0 (21)	47,6 (10)	52,4 (11)	100,0 (21)
M	100,0 (71)	32,4 (23)	36,6 (26)	31,0 (22)	50,7 (36)	100,0 (71)	49,3 (35)	100,0 (71)
KD	100,0 (8)	25,0 (2)	37,5 (3)	37,5 (3)	37,5 (3)	62,5 (5)	100,0 (8)	100,0 (8)
SD	100,0 (17)	23,5 (4)	41,2 (7)	35,3 (6)	58,8 (10)	70,6 (12)	70,6 (12)	100,0 (17)

Note: The table shows the distribution of profile party affiliation in the profiles presented to respondents, by respondent's top-ranked party. Each respondent saw five profiles. Cell entries report the percentage of respondents within each group who were shown each profile type. For instance, 100 percent of Left Party (V) respondents were assigned to co-partisan profiles, in line with the experimental design. The number of observations is shown in parentheses. Party abbreviations: the Left Party (V), the Green Party (MP), the Social Democrats (S), the Center Party (C), the Liberals (L), the Moderates (M), the Christian Democrats (KD), and the Sweden Democrats (SD).

Appendix B. Sample characteristics and descriptive statistics

Sample characteristics (Tables B1-B3)

Table B1 Sociodemographic characteristics of the sample compared with the Swedish population aged 18–35

Variable	Category	Sample	Population (18-35)
Gender	Women	69.0	48.5
	Men	29.5	51.5
	Other/Prefer not to specify	1.5	-
Education	Low	9.7	58.1
	Medium	39.0	17.8
	High	51.3	24.1
Residential area	Large city	77.5	41.0
	City or larger town	16.2	40.5
	Small town or countryside	6.3	18.5

Source: Statistics Sweden (SCB) (gender: $n = 2,378,543$; education: $n = 2,281,105$; residential area: $n = 2,344,316$).

Note: Values are percentages. Percentages may not sum to 100 due to rounding. This table presents a descriptive comparison between the sample and register data for the Swedish population aged 18–35.

For gender, “Other/Prefer not to specify” is not reported in Statistics Sweden (SCB) data.

Education is measured as highest completed or currently ongoing level: low = primary and upper secondary school, medium = tertiary education, not college/university and college/university, 3 years or less, high = college/university, longer than 3 years, and postgraduate education. Individuals with missing information on ($n = 97,438$) were excluded from the estimates.

Residential area is based on the classification of Swedish municipalities by the Swedish Association of Local Authorities and Regions (SKR, 2025). In the survey, “small town” and “countryside” were separate response options but are combined here for comparability.

Marital status and romantic/sexual attraction are excluded as there is no register data on this.

Table B2 **Top-ranked party in the sample compared to reference groups**

	Sample	SOM Survey 2024 (18–35)	Polls of polls April 2026	Election 2022
Left Party (V)	29.1	13.4	8.1	6.8
Green Party (MP)	15.2	8.4	7.0	5.1
Social Democrats (S)	28.4	26.1	32.0	30.3
Center Party (C)	7.3	7.0	6.0	6.7
Liberals (L)	3.6	3.9	2.5	4.6
Moderates (M)	12.1	20.1	17.9	19.1
Christian Democrats (KD)	1.4	3.0	5.2	5.3
Sweden Democrats (SD)	2.9	13.6	29.3	20.5
Other*	-	4.5	2.0	1.5

Sources: SOM Institute (2026), The National SOM Survey 2024 (n = 2,010); Polls of polls. (Mätningarnas mätningar), a weighted aggregate of opinion polls (SCB, Verian, Demoskop, Novus, Ipsos, Indikator) maintained by the Swedish National Election Studies Program, University of Gothenburg (updated 2026-05-20); Valmyndigheten. (2022). *2022 Swedish Election Results*.

Note: Values are percentages. Percentages may not sum to 100 due to rounding. Respondents were asked to rank the eight parliamentary parties only and other parties are therefore not reported for the sample.

Table B3 **Partisan strength in the sample compared with the 2024 SOM Survey**

	Strong partisan	Weak partisan	Non-partisan
Sample	17.0	46.2	36.8
SOM Survey 2024 (18–35)	12.1	37.1	50.8

Source: SOM Institute (2026), The National SOM Survey 2024 (n = 1,958)

Note: To ensure comparability with the experimental sample, the SOM comparison is restricted to individuals aged 18-35. Values are percentages. Percentages may not sum to 100 due to rounding. In the experiment, partisan strength was measured using the question “Do you consider yourself a convinced supporter of your best party?”, while in the SOM Survey the wording was “Do you consider yourself a convinced supporter of this party?”. In both surveys, the response options were “Yes, very convinced”, “Yes, somewhat convinced”, and “No”. These responses were recoded into three categories: Strong partisan (“Yes, very much so”), Weak partisan (“Yes, somewhat”), and Non-partisan (“No”).

Descriptive statistics (Tables B4-B6, Figure B1)

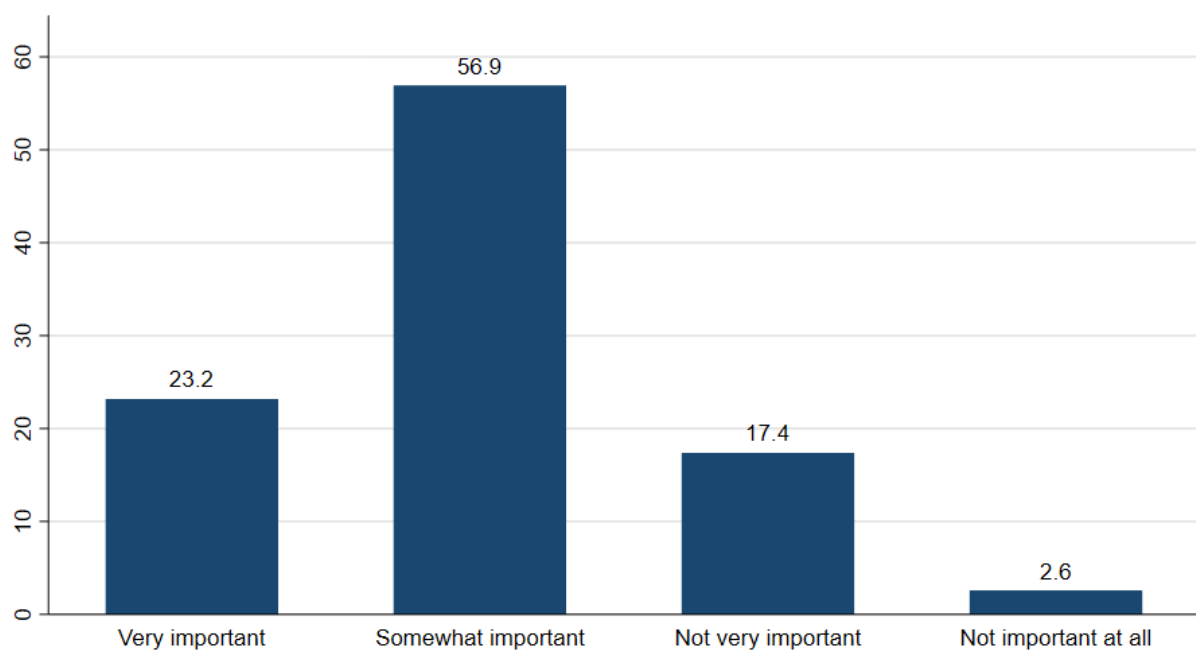
Table B4 Mean party ranking by respondents' top-ranked party

	V	MP	S	C	L	M	KD	SD	n
V	1.0	2.5	2.7	4.1	5.2	6.0	6.7	7.8	171
MP	2.9	1.0	2.8	3.8	5.2	5.7	6.7	7.9	89
S	3.6	3.5	1.0	3.7	5.3	4.8	6.6	7.5	167
C	5.9	3.9	3.0	1.0	4.2	4.7	6.2	7.1	43
L	6.5	5.4	4.1	3.6	1.0	3.5	5.2	6.7	21
M	7.1	6.6	4.0	4.6	3.7	1.0	4.2	4.8	71
KD	7.5	6.8	5.3	4.6	4.6	2.1	1.0	4.1	8
SD	6.3	6.5	4.7	6.1	4.2	3.4	3.9	1.0	17

Note: The table shows the mean rankings assigned to each column party by respondents whose top-ranked party appears in the row (1 = most preferred, 8 = least preferred). Cell colors range from green (most favorable) to red (least favorable) and are scaled separately within each row, meaning that the same value may appear in different shades in different rows. The question was “Rank the eight parliamentary parties, from your best party to your worst party”. Party abbreviations: the Left Party (V), the Green Party (MP), the Social Democrats (S), the Center Party (C), the Liberals (L), the Moderates (M), the Christian Democrats (KD), and the Sweden Democrats (SD)

Following the experimental component, respondents were asked “How important is it to have the same political views as your partner?”, with four response options ranging from “Not important at all” to “Very important”. This was modeled after a question from Indikator (2025). This question was ultimately not included in the main analysis, but is reported in Figure B1 as supplementary descriptive information. The results show that a majority, almost 83% of all respondents, consider shared political views at least somewhat important in a partner. This suggests that political similarity is something the respondents consider in partner selection, consistent with the experimental findings.

Figure B1 Perceived importance of sharing political views with a romantic partner



Note: N = 587. The figure shows respondents’ answers to the question: “How important is it to share the same political views as your partner?”. Percentages do not sum to 100 due to rounding.

Table B5 Descriptive statistics for outcome variables

Outcome measure	Mean	SD	n
Relationship interest	2.69	1.32	2935
Date interest	2.91	1.36	2935

Note: The primary outcome variable, used in the main analysis, is relationship interest. Both items were introduced by the prompt “How interest would you be in:”, or “If you were single, how interested would you be in;” for respondents in a relationship. Relationship interest was measured by “Pursuing a romantic relationship with the person in this profile” and date interest by “Going on a date with the person in this profile?”.

Table B6 Correlation matrix of independent variables

	Same party affiliation	Ideological distance	Out-bloc affiliation	PRR affiliation
Same party affiliation	1.000			
Ideological distance	-0.611***	1.000		
Out-bloc affiliation	-0.408***	0.784***	1.000	
PRR affiliation	-0.245***	0.432***	0.425***	1.000

Note: Pairwise correlations between the independent variables. Same party = dummy variable coded 1 if the respondent’s top-ranked party matches the party in the profile; Ideological distance = absolute difference in overall left-right position between the respondent’s top-ranked party and the profile party, based on CHES 2024 expert placements; Out-bloc affiliation = dummy variable coded 1 if the profile party belongs to the opposite affective bloc from the respondent’s top-ranked party; PRR affiliation = dummy variable coded 1 if the profile party is the Sweden Democrats (SD). * $p < 0.05$ ** $p < 0.01$ *** $p < 0.001$

Appendix C. Standardized estimates

Table C1 replicates the main analysis with a standardized outcome variable, where the relationship interest scale has been standardized to have a mean of zero and a standard deviation of one. This facilitates comparison with prior (and hopefully future) vignette survey experiments on direct political matching (Easton & Holbein, 2021; Huber & Malhotra, 2017; Nicholson et al., 2016).

Table C1 **Main analysis with standardized outcome variable**

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	0.855*** (0.031)			
Ideological distance		-0.260*** (0.007)	-0.208*** (0.011)	-0.179*** (0.011)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.285*** (0.052)	-0.206*** (0.050)
PRR affiliation				-0.539*** (0.037)
2 years younger	-0.241*** (0.045)	-0.249*** (0.037)	-0.252*** (0.037)	-0.253*** (0.035)
2 years older	-0.027 (0.043)	-0.043 (0.036)	-0.040 (0.035)	-0.048 (0.034)
Short	-0.199*** (0.045)	-0.178*** (0.036)	-0.183*** (0.035)	-0.201*** (0.034)
Tall	0.060 (0.047)	0.081* (0.040)	0.075 (0.039)	0.062 (0.037)
University education	0.178*** (0.038)	0.173*** (0.031)	0.174*** (0.031)	0.173*** (0.030)
Observations	2935	2935	2935	2935
Within R ²	0.190	0.465	0.474	0.521

Note: The outcome variable has been standardized to have a mean of zero and a standard deviation of one. Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables in all models. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Appendix D. Robustness tests

Alternative outcome variable (Table D1)

Table D1 replicates the main analysis using date interest as the outcome variable instead of relationship interest. While relationship interest is intended to capture long-term partner preferences, date interest is intended to reflect short-term romantic interest. The item uses the same introductory text (“If you were single how/How interested would you be in”), followed by the question “Going on a date with the person in this profile?”. The outcome is measured on the same five-point scale.

Table D1 Fixed-effects regression on date interest

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.132*** (0.042)			
Ideological distance		-0.346*** (0.010)	-0.272*** (0.015)	-0.228*** (0.015)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.407*** (0.070)	-0.287*** (0.066)
PRR affiliation				-0.819*** (0.050)
2 years younger	-0.338*** (0.061)	-0.348*** (0.050)	-0.353*** (0.050)	-0.354*** (0.047)
2 years older	-0.033 (0.058)	-0.054 (0.049)	-0.050 (0.048)	-0.062 (0.045)
Short	-0.292*** (0.061)	-0.264*** (0.049)	-0.271*** (0.049)	-0.298*** (0.046)
Tall	0.067 (0.063)	0.095 (0.055)	0.087 (0.054)	0.068 (0.051)
University education	0.258*** (0.050)	0.251*** (0.042)	0.252*** (0.042)	0.251*** (0.039)
Observations	2935	2935	2935	2935
Within R ²	0.187	0.457	0.466	0.526

Note: The dependent variable is date interest. Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

The results are largely consistent with the main analysis across all four models, suggesting that respondents did not strongly differentiate between long- and short-term romantic interest

when evaluating profiles. The coefficients differ slightly in magnitude, but not substantively. The most notable difference concerns the PRR affiliation coefficient, which is somewhat stronger here (-0.82) than in the main analysis (-0.71).

Alternative ideological measures (Tables D2-D5)

Tables D3-D5 replicate the main analysis using three alternative measures of ideological distance. While the main analysis relies on overall left-right placement from the Chapel Hill Expert Survey (CHES) (Rovny et al., 2025), the analysis is also run using CHES economic left-right placements (D3), CHES GAL-TAN placements (D4), and left-right placements based on mean voter perceptions from the 2022 Swedish National Election studies (SNES) (Oscarsson et al., 2024) (D5). As in the main analysis, ideological distance is operationalized as the absolute difference between the respondent’s top-ranked party and the party in the profile. Party placements across all four measures are reported in Table D2.

Table D2 Party placements across ideological measures

	Chapel Hill Expert Survey (CHES)			Swedish National Election Studies (SNES)
	Overall left-right	Economic left-right	GAL-TAN	Left-right
Left Party (V)	1.6	1.9	2.4	0.8
Green Party (MP)	2.7	3.2	1.9	2.5
Social Democrats (S)	3.7	3.7	4.7	3.1
Center Party (C)	5.9	7.8	2.9	4.7
Liberals (L)	6.7	7.3	4.5	6.4
Moderates (M)	7.6	7.9	6.5	8.5
Christian Democrats (KD)	8.0	7.3	7.8	8.0
Sweden Democrats (SD)	8.5	6.3	9.0	8.5

Source: CHES placements are expert-based estimates from the 2024 Chapel Hill Expert Survey (Rovny et al., 2025), where overall left-right, economic left-right, and GAL-TAN corresponds to the variables lrgen, lrecon, and galtan. SNES placements are based on mean voter perceptions from the 2022 Swedish National Election Studies (CSES module), variables q327a-q327h where respondents placed each party on a left-right scale (Oscarsson et al., 2024).

Note: All measures range from 0-10. Parties are ordered by their CHES overall left-right placement, which serves as the measure of ideological distance in the main analysis.

Research on affective polarization in multi-party systems often measures ideological distance along both a traditional left-right and a socio-cultural dimension, the latter commonly captured using the GAL-TAN scale (Hooghe et al., 2002). Both Hartevelde (2021) and Gidron et al. (2023) find that cultural divides generate stronger partisan affect than economic ones. The overall left-right measure was nonetheless chosen for the main analysis, as the Swedish party system has been described as relatively one dimensional, with new conflicts largely integrated into a left-right logic (Oscarsson, 1998). To assess whether the results are sensitive to this choice or differ across dimensions, Tables D3 and D4 replicate the analysis using CHES economic left-right placements and CHES GAL-TAN placements, respectively.

Table D3 **Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, CHES economic issues**

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.124*** (0.041)			
CHES economic distance		-0.283*** (0.011)	-0.131*** (0.011)	-0.170*** (0.011)
Out-bloc affiliation			-1.070*** (0.048)	-0.634*** (0.052)
PRR affiliation				-1.007*** (0.047)
2 years younger	-0.318*** (0.059)	-0.307*** (0.057)	-0.331*** (0.051)	-0.331*** (0.047)
2 years older	-0.036 (0.057)	-0.013 (0.055)	-0.028 (0.049)	-0.048 (0.044)
Short	-0.262*** (0.059)	-0.214*** (0.055)	-0.242*** (0.048)	-0.263*** (0.045)
Tall	0.079 (0.061)	0.117* (0.059)	0.091 (0.053)	0.079 (0.049)
University education	0.235*** (0.050)	0.235*** (0.046)	0.233*** (0.044)	0.230*** (0.039)
Observations	2935	2935	2935	2935
Within R ²	0.190	0.273	0.415	0.511

Note: CHES economic distance is based on expert placements on economic left-right issues, such as privatization, taxes, regulation, government spending, and the welfare state (CHES variable: *lrecon*). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table D4 **Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, CHES GAL-TAN**

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.124*** (0.041)			
CHES GAL-TAN distance		-0.334*** (0.009)	-0.222*** (0.012)	-0.147*** (0.016)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.664*** (0.060)	-0.724*** (0.058)
PRR affiliation				-0.522*** (0.061)
2 years younger	-0.318*** (0.059)	-0.337*** (0.050)	-0.342*** (0.049)	-0.340*** (0.048)
2 years older	-0.036 (0.057)	-0.076 (0.050)	-0.064 (0.048)	-0.062 (0.047)
Short	-0.262*** (0.059)	-0.286*** (0.050)	-0.279*** (0.047)	-0.289*** (0.046)
Tall	0.079 (0.061)	0.056 (0.054)	0.060 (0.052)	0.054 (0.051)
University education	0.235*** (0.050)	0.224*** (0.043)	0.226*** (0.042)	0.228*** (0.042)
Observations	2935	2935	2935	2935
Within R ²	0.190	0.422	0.460	0.477

Note: CHES GAL-TAN distance is based on expert placements on a libertarian/postmaterialist-traditional/authoritarian dimension (commonly referred to as GAL-TAN), capturing views on democratic freedom, social issues, and cultural values (CHES variable: galton). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

The results from Tables D3 and D4 are broadly consistent with the main analysis, with all effects remaining statistically significant and in the expected direction. This supports the conclusion that the findings are robust to the choice of ideological measure. Still, the relative magnitude of the coefficients varies across measures, and some notable differences emerge.

In Table D3, the ideological distance coefficient in Model 2 is weaker than in the main analysis (-0.28 vs -0.34). The lower within R² (0.27 vs 0.47) further suggests that economic distance alone explains less of the variation in romantic interest than overall left-right distance. In Model 4, the ideological distance coefficient is similarly weaker (-0.17 vs -0.24), while the out-bloc (-0.63 vs -0.27) and PRR (-1.01 vs -0.71) coefficients are larger. This

likely reflects the clustering of several parties in the center-right on the economic dimension (C: 7.8, L: 7.3, M: 7.9, KD: 7.3), while SD is located at a lower position on the scale (6.3). As a result, out-bloc and PRR affiliation capture more of the variation than in the main analysis.

In Table D4, the ideological distance coefficient in Model 2 is similar to the main analysis (-0.33 vs -0.34) and the within R^2 is also comparable (0.42 vs 0.47). However, the coefficient declines more between Model 2 and Model 4 than in the main analysis (-0.33 to -0.15 vs -0.34 to -0.24). In Model 4, the out-bloc coefficient is considerably larger than in the main analysis (-0.72 vs -0.27). Together, this pattern suggests that Swedish affective blocs are more clearly structured along the socio-cultural dimension than the economic dimension. Moreover, the PRR coefficient is smaller (-0.52 vs -0.71), consistent with SD's somewhat more extreme position on the GAL-TAN scale than on the overall left-right dimension (9.0 vs 8.5).

Comparing the two measures, GAL-TAN distance produces a larger coefficient in Model 2 (-0.33) than economic distance (-0.28), and explains more of the within-respondent variation ($R^2 = 0.42$ vs 0.27). This suggests that the findings of Hartevelde (2021) and Gidron et al. (2023), that socio-cultural divides generate stronger partisan affect than economic ones, may extend to the context of romantic partner selection.

Next, the third alternative measure of ideological distance, reported in Table D5 uses party placements based on mean voter perceptions from the 2022 SNES. The rationale for using the CHES measure as the primary measure is that it follows prior work on affective polarization (Hartevelde, 2021), and because the 2024 CHES wave more closely reflects party positions at the time of data collection. The latter is particularly relevant given the significant shifts in the Swedish political landscape following the 2022 election (see Section 3.1). However, voter perception may in some ways be more relevant in the context of partner selection, as individuals are likely to evaluate potential partners based on their own understanding of where parties stand rather than objective ideological distances.

Table D5 **Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, SNES ideological distance**

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.124*** (0.041)			
SNES ideological distance		-0.290*** (0.009)	-0.256*** (0.016)	-0.239*** (0.016)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.201* (0.082)	0.000 (0.080)
PRR affiliation				-0.815*** (0.048)
2 years younger	-0.318*** (0.059)	-0.337*** (0.049)	-0.338*** (0.049)	-0.338*** (0.046)
2 years older	-0.036 (0.057)	-0.058 (0.048)	-0.055 (0.047)	-0.069 (0.045)
Short	-0.262*** (0.059)	-0.241*** (0.047)	-0.244*** (0.047)	-0.269*** (0.044)
Tall	0.079 (0.061)	0.099 (0.052)	0.096 (0.052)	0.079 (0.049)
University education	0.235*** (0.050)	0.232*** (0.042)	0.232*** (0.042)	0.230*** (0.039)
Observations	2935	2935	2935	2935
Within R ²	0.190	0.450	0.452	0.516

Note: SNES ideological distance is based on mean voter perceptions from the 2022 Swedish National Election Studies (CSES module), variables q327a-q327h where respondents placed each party on a left-right scale (Oscarsson et al., 2024). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

The results in Table D5 are partially consistent with the main analysis. Ideological distance and PRR affiliation remain statistically significant and of comparable magnitude (-0.24 and -0.82 respectively, vs -0.24 and -0.71 in the main analysis). The within R² in Model 2 is also similar to the main analysis (0.45 vs 0.47), suggesting that voter-perceived and expert-based placements explain comparable amounts of variation. However, the out-bloc coefficient is substantially weaker in Model 3 (-0.20 vs -0.37) and drops to zero in Model 4. This may reflect that the ideological gap between blocs is perceived as larger by voters (1.7 points between C and L) than on the CHES overall left-right measure (0.8 points). As a result, the SNES ideological variable may capture more of the variation otherwise associated with

affective bloc affiliation. The remaining out-bloc effect in Model 3 appears to be driven by SD profiles, as it disappears once PRR affiliation is controlled for.

Excluding respondents aged 18–19 (Table D6)

As mentioned in Section 3.6, the joint variation of age and education generates unrealistic profiles for the youngest respondents. These respondents were included in the main analysis, as research suggests that impossible attribute combinations have limited effects on response behaviour (Bansak & Jenke, 2025). Table D6 replicates the main analysis excluding respondents aged 18 and 19 to assess whether the results are sensitive to their inclusion.

Table D6 Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, excluding respondents aged 18-19

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.140*** (0.042)			
Ideological distance		-0.348*** (0.009)	-0.277*** (0.015)	-0.239*** (0.015)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.388*** (0.070)	-0.278*** (0.067)
PRR affiliation				-0.706*** (0.051)
2 years younger	-0.304*** (0.059)	-0.323*** (0.048)	-0.327*** (0.048)	-0.323*** (0.046)
2 years older	-0.066 (0.059)	-0.088 (0.048)	-0.083 (0.047)	-0.090* (0.045)
Short	-0.257*** (0.061)	-0.244*** (0.047)	-0.251*** (0.047)	-0.271*** (0.045)
Tall	0.108 (0.062)	0.126* (0.052)	0.117* (0.051)	0.105* (0.049)
University education	0.232*** (0.052)	0.213*** (0.041)	0.214*** (0.042)	0.217*** (0.040)
Observations	2760	2760	2760	2760
Within R ²	0.192	0.477	0.486	0.532

Note: Respondents aged 18 and 19 are excluded due to impossible attribute. Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

The results in Table D6 are broadly consistent with the main analysis. All effects remain statistically significant and of comparable magnitude, including the nonpolitical attributes. The within R^2 values are also similar to the main analysis, reaching 0.53 in Model 4 compared to 0.52 in the main analysis. Overall, this suggests that the findings are robust to the inclusion of respondents who were presented with impossible attribute combinations.

PRR-specificity (Table D7)

Table D7 serves as a robustness test for H4 by replicating the main analysis with an additional dummy variable for Left Party (V) profiles to assess whether the observed PRR penalty reflects a general dislike of ideological extremity or is specific to these parties. While research on affective polarization suggests the latter (Bantel, 2023; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021) this has not been tested in the context of partner selection. The Left Party (V) serves as the natural comparison case, as it is the ideologically most peripheral party on the left on the CHES overall left-right scale (see Table 2).

Table D7 Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, including Left Party (V) profile dummy

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.124*** (0.041)			
Ideological distance		-0.342*** (0.009)	-0.274*** (0.015)	-0.251*** (0.017)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.374*** (0.069)	-0.216** (0.070)
PRR affiliation				-0.676*** (0.051)
Left Party (V) affiliation				0.128* (0.060)
2 years younger	-0.318*** (0.059)	-0.328*** (0.049)	-0.332*** (0.048)	-0.332*** (0.046)
2 years older	-0.036 (0.057)	-0.057 (0.047)	-0.053 (0.046)	-0.061 (0.044)
Short	-0.262*** (0.059)	-0.235*** (0.047)	-0.241*** (0.046)	-0.264*** (0.044)
Tall	0.079 (0.061)	0.106* (0.052)	0.099 (0.051)	0.079 (0.049)
University education	0.235*** (0.050)	0.228*** (0.041)	0.229*** (0.041)	0.227*** (0.039)
Observations	2935	2935	2935	2935
Within R ²	0.190	0.465	0.474	0.522

Note: The table additionally includes a dummy for Left Party (V) profiles. Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

The results in Table D7 show that the PRR coefficient remains negative and statistically significant ($-0.68, p < 0.001$) when including the dummy for V profiles, while the V profile coefficient is positive, and only marginally significant ($0.13, p < 0.05$). The opposing direction of the two effects, despite both parties being ideologically peripheral, suggests that the PRR penalty observed in the main analysis is specific to these parties. This provides further support for H4 and is consistent with prior research on affective polarization (Bantel, 2023; Reiljan & Ryan, 2021).

Appendix E. Heterogeneity tests

The following tables examine heterogeneity in the main effects across subgroups, replicating the analysis by affective bloc membership, gender, partisan identity, and relationship status.

By affective bloc-membership (Tables E1-E2)

Tables E1 and E2 replicate the main analysis separately for left- and right-bloc respondents, as Sleiman et al. (2025) find stronger effects among left-bloc respondents, though no general consensus exists. As described in Section 3.3.2., the left bloc is operationalized as S, MP, C and V, while the right bloc contains KD, L, M and SD. The right-bloc sample is considerably smaller ($n = 117$) than the left-bloc sample ($n = 479$), which means the right-bloc estimates should be interpreted with some caution.

Table E1 Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, left-bloc

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.188*** (0.044)			
Ideological distance		-0.388*** (0.009)	-0.292*** (0.015)	-0.261*** (0.016)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.533*** (0.072)	-0.396*** (0.070)
PRR affiliation				-0.495*** (0.054)
2 years younger	-0.327*** (0.068)	-0.335*** (0.051)	-0.348*** (0.050)	-0.343*** (0.049)
2 years older	-0.049 (0.066)	-0.067 (0.049)	-0.067 (0.048)	-0.076 (0.047)
Short	-0.234*** (0.067)	-0.227*** (0.049)	-0.242*** (0.047)	-0.248*** (0.047)
Tall	0.118 (0.069)	0.122* (0.053)	0.104* (0.052)	0.100* (0.051)
University education	0.250*** (0.056)	0.245*** (0.042)	0.241*** (0.042)	0.239*** (0.041)
Observations	2350	2350	2350	2350
Within R ²	0.200	0.552	0.571	0.587

Note: Sample restricted to left-bloc respondents (S, MP, C and V; $n = 479$). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E1 shows that the results for left-bloc respondents closely mirror the main analysis, which is expected given that these respondents are overrepresented in the sample. The most notable differences concern the out-bloc coefficient, which is somewhat stronger (-0.40 vs -0.27 in Model 4), and the PRR coefficient, which is weaker (-0.50 vs -0.71). This is consistent with SD being classified as an out-bloc party for these respondents, meaning that part of the PRR penalty is captured by the out-bloc variable. The within R^2 is somewhat higher than in the main analysis across all models, reaching 0.59 in Model 4 compared to 0.52.

Table E2 Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, right-bloc

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	0.855*** (0.098)			
Ideological distance		-0.172*** (0.021)	-0.273*** (0.038)	-0.222*** (0.037)
Out-bloc affiliation			0.534** (0.177)	0.141 (0.176)
PRR affiliation				-0.652*** (0.122)
2 years younger	-0.283* (0.119)	-0.290* (0.118)	-0.308** (0.115)	-0.315** (0.113)
2 years older	0.034 (0.104)	0.022 (0.108)	-0.003 (0.108)	0.002 (0.104)
Short	-0.397** (0.118)	-0.352** (0.110)	-0.369** (0.110)	-0.385*** (0.110)
Tall	-0.089 (0.133)	-0.038 (0.134)	-0.055 (0.137)	-0.048 (0.133)
University education	0.148 (0.112)	0.132 (0.111)	0.109 (0.109)	0.145 (0.103)
Observations	585	585	585	585
Within R^2	0.156	0.192	0.207	0.251

Note: Sample restricted to right-bloc respondents (KD, L, M, SD; $n = 117$). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

In Table E2, which shows results for right-bloc respondents, most effects are statistically significant and in the expected direction. A notable difference emerges in Model 3, where the effect of out-bloc affiliation is positive (0.53) in contrast to the negative effect observed in the main analysis (-0.37). It also does not reach the same level of significance ($p < 0.01$). This

may reflect that SD profiles belong to the right bloc and are therefore not captured by the out-bloc dummy. If they are evaluated more negatively than ideological distance predicts, this may inflate the relative ratings of left-bloc profiles, producing a positive out-bloc coefficient. Consistent with this interpretation, the out-bloc coefficient becomes statistically insignificant once PRR affiliation is included in Model 4. The within R^2 is lower than in the main analysis across all models, reaching only 0.25 in Model 4 compared to 0.52.

Comparing the two affective blocs, the same-party effect in Model 1 is larger among left-bloc respondents (1.19 vs 0.86), which is consistent with Sleiman et al. (2025). In Model 4, the effect of ideological distance is also stronger among left-bloc respondents, while the PRR coefficient is more pronounced among right-bloc respondents. The largest difference, however, concerns the out-bloc coefficient, as described above. The within R^2 also differs substantially between blocs, suggesting that the model fits better for left-bloc respondents.

By partisan identity (Table E3-E4)

Tables E3 and E4 replicate the main analysis separately for respondents with and without a partisan identity. Immediately following the ranking of parties (see Section 3.3.2) respondents were asked “Do you consider yourself a convinced supporter of your best party?”. The question was modelled on a similar item for the annual SOM Survey (University of Gothenburg, SOM Institute, 2026). Those who answered “Yes, very convinced” or “Yes, somewhat convinced”, are classified as partisans (n = 371) while those who answered “No” are classified as non-partisans (n = 216). Prior research suggests that affective polarization and direct political matching are more pronounced among individuals with a strong partisan identity (Reiljan & Ryan, 2021; Sleiman et al., 2025), motivating this heterogeneity analysis.

Table E3 Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, respondents with a partisan identity

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.274*** (0.050)			
Ideological distance		-0.383*** (0.011)	-0.304*** (0.020)	-0.267*** (0.020)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.434*** (0.094)	-0.373*** (0.092)
PRR affiliation				-0.547*** (0.061)
2 years younger	-0.324*** (0.079)	-0.310*** (0.061)	-0.313*** (0.061)	-0.311*** (0.059)
2 years older	0.022 (0.075)	-0.034 (0.058)	-0.033 (0.057)	-0.043 (0.056)
Short	-0.279*** (0.075)	-0.251*** (0.056)	-0.262*** (0.055)	-0.266*** (0.053)
Tall	0.124 (0.080)	0.123 (0.063)	0.112 (0.062)	0.113 (0.061)
University education	0.266*** (0.063)	0.268*** (0.048)	0.268*** (0.049)	0.267*** (0.047)
Observations	1855	1855	1855	1855
Within R ²	0.219	0.560	0.569	0.592

Note: Sample restricted to respondents with a partisan identity (n = 371). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E3 shows that among partisans, all political effects are statistically significant and broadly consistent with the main analysis, though generally somewhat stronger. For instance, in Model 1, the same-party coefficient is larger than in the main analysis (1.27 vs 1.12). The within R^2 is also higher across all models, reaching 0.59 in Model 4 compared to 0.52. In contrast, the PRR coefficient is smaller than in the main analysis (-0.55 vs -0.71).

Table E4 Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, respondents without a partisan identity

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	0.862*** (0.067)			
Ideological distance		-0.253*** (0.016)	-0.199*** (0.022)	-0.171*** (0.022)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.298** (0.098)	-0.131 (0.091)
PRR affiliation				-0.901*** (0.080)
2 years younger	-0.305*** (0.084)	-0.337*** (0.077)	-0.343*** (0.077)	-0.358*** (0.072)
2 years older	-0.128 (0.084)	-0.105 (0.077)	-0.098 (0.077)	-0.105 (0.070)
Short	-0.237* (0.096)	-0.214* (0.084)	-0.214* (0.083)	-0.283*** (0.079)
Tall	-0.008 (0.095)	0.042 (0.088)	0.039 (0.087)	-0.016 (0.081)
University education	0.192* (0.080)	0.175* (0.072)	0.177* (0.072)	0.177** (0.068)
Observations	1080	1080	1080	1080
Within R^2	0.142	0.286	0.295	0.398

Note: Sample restricted to respondents without a partisan identity ($n = 216$). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E4 shows that among non-partisans, most effects are statistically significant and in the same direction as in the main analysis, though generally somewhat weaker. The within R^2 is lower across all models, reaching 0.40 in Model 4 compared to 0.52. By contrast, the PRR coefficient is larger than in the main analysis (-0.90 vs -0.71). The most notable difference is the effect of out-bloc affiliation, which is statistically significant in Model 3, but loses its

significance once PRR affiliation is included in Model 4. This suggests that the out-bloc effect in Model 3 is largely driven by particularly negative evaluations of SD profiles.

Comparing respondents with and without a partisan identity, the same-party effect in Model 1 is larger among partisans (1.27 vs 0.86), in line with prior studies (Reiljan & Ryan, 2021; Sleiman et al., 2025). The same pattern holds for most other effects, with the exception of PRR affiliation, which has a considerably stronger negative effect among non-partisans (-0.90 vs -0.55). Among non-partisans, the out-bloc effect also disappears once PRR affiliation is accounted for. The within R^2 is also higher among partisans (0.59 vs 0.40 in Model 4). Together, this suggests that party identity strengthens political matching in partner selection, with the exception of the PRR penalty, which is more pronounced among non-partisans. This pattern is reminiscent of negative partisanship and negative voting (e.g., Garzia & Ferreira da Silva, 2022), where political behaviour is driven more by opposition to a specific party than by identification with one, suggesting that a similar dynamic may extend to partner selection.

By gender (Tables E5-E6)

Tables E5 and E6 replicate the main analysis separately for male and female respondents. Prior experimental research on direct political matching find that women tend to exhibit stronger same-party preferences than men (Nicholson et al., 2016; Sleiman et al., 2025), though the evidence remains limited and no clear theoretical explanation for this pattern has been established. The number of male respondents is considerably smaller ($n = 173$) than the number of female respondents ($n = 405$), which means the male estimates should be interpreted with caution. Respondents who identify as another gender or did not want to specify their gender ($n = 45$) are excluded from these analyses.

Table E5 **Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, female respondents**

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.182*** (0.049)			
Ideological distance		-0.357*** (0.011)	-0.271*** (0.018)	-0.229*** (0.018)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.472*** (0.086)	-0.352*** (0.082)
PRR affiliation				-0.731*** (0.062)
2 years younger	-0.450*** (0.072)	-0.458*** (0.058)	-0.466*** (0.058)	-0.464*** (0.055)
2 years older	-0.026 (0.070)	-0.049 (0.059)	-0.051 (0.057)	-0.064 (0.055)
Short	-0.287*** (0.070)	-0.265*** (0.056)	-0.274*** (0.055)	-0.313*** (0.053)
Tall	0.163* (0.077)	0.192** (0.064)	0.182** (0.063)	0.158** (0.059)
University education	0.277*** (0.061)	0.240*** (0.049)	0.234*** (0.050)	0.229*** (0.047)
Observations	2025	2025	2025	2025
Within R ²	0.216	0.489	0.502	0.547

Note: Sample restricted to female respondents ($n = 405$). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level.
* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E5 shows that the results for female respondents are similar to the main results, which is expected given that women are overrepresented in the full sample. Most political coefficients are somewhat larger than in the main analysis (e.g., out-bloc affiliation -0.35 vs -0.27 in Model 4), except for the ideological distance coefficients in Models 3 and 4. The within R^2 is also somewhat higher across all models, reaching 0.55 in Model 4 compared to 0.52 in the main analysis.

Table E6 Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, male respondents

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	0.970*** (0.075)			
Ideological distance		-0.298*** (0.018)	-0.279*** (0.025)	-0.250*** (0.025)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.107 (0.102)	-0.038 (0.094)
PRR affiliation				-0.655*** (0.082)
2 years younger	-0.032 (0.102)	-0.040 (0.086)	-0.040 (0.086)	-0.057 (0.082)
2 years older	-0.103 (0.097)	-0.089 (0.081)	-0.084 (0.081)	-0.098 (0.073)
Short	-0.180 (0.107)	-0.139 (0.088)	-0.141 (0.088)	-0.128 (0.083)
Tall	-0.088 (0.097)	-0.051 (0.086)	-0.053 (0.086)	-0.058 (0.086)
University education	0.172 (0.090)	0.214** (0.077)	0.219** (0.077)	0.228** (0.073)
Observations	865	865	865	865
Within R^2	0.156	0.416	0.417	0.470

Note: Sample restricted to male respondents ($n = 173$). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

The results in Table E6 show that most effects are statistically significant and of similar magnitude to the main analysis. A notable difference, however, concerns the out-bloc coefficient, which is not statistically significant in either Model 3 or Model 4. The within R^2 is somewhat lower across all models (0.47 vs 0.52 in Model 4).

Comparing male and female respondents, the same-party coefficient is somewhat larger among women (1.18 vs 0.97), consistent with the findings of Nicholson et al. (2016) and Sleiman et al. (2025). In Model 4, the effect of ideological distance is somewhat stronger among male respondents, while the effect of PRR affiliation is stronger for female respondents. The within R^2 is higher for female respondents than for male respondents (e.g., 0.55 vs 0.47 in Model 4). The most striking difference concerns out-bloc affiliation, which is statistically significant and negative among women, but not among men. This pattern is similar to the differences between left- and right-bloc respondents (Tables E1-E2). However, gender and bloc membership are only modestly correlated in the sample ($r = 0.12$), suggesting that the observed bloc and gender differences are not primarily driven by each other.

By relationship status (Tables E7-E8)

Tables E7 and E8 replicate the main analysis separately for respondents currently in a romantic relationship and those who are not. Relationship status was measured using the question “What is your marital status?”, based on the SNES (Oscarsson et al., 2024). Respondents who answered “In a relationship”, “Cohabitant” and “Married/in a registered partnership” are classified as in a relationship ($n = 309$) while those who answered “Single” form the comparison group ($n = 278$). Restricting the sample to single respondents could arguably better capture active dating preferences, as these respondents may find it easier to engage with the hypothetical scenario. Nonetheless, both groups were retained in the main analysis to increase sample size.

Table E7 **Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, single respondents**

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.092*** (0.061)			
Ideological distance		-0.335*** (0.013)	-0.260*** (0.022)	-0.220*** (0.023)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.411*** (0.104)	-0.333*** (0.098)
PRR affiliation				-0.675*** (0.070)
2 years younger	-0.349*** (0.085)	-0.343*** (0.073)	-0.352*** (0.072)	-0.343*** (0.071)
2 years older	-0.125 (0.082)	-0.079 (0.067)	-0.067 (0.067)	-0.062 (0.065)
Short	-0.313*** (0.079)	-0.260*** (0.065)	-0.282*** (0.063)	-0.305*** (0.061)
Tall	0.151 (0.092)	0.117 (0.076)	0.104 (0.074)	0.086 (0.071)
University education	0.175* (0.068)	0.188** (0.057)	0.192*** (0.057)	0.195*** (0.055)
Observations	1390	1390	1390	1390
Within R ²	0.195	0.467	0.477	0.521

Note: Sample restricted to respondents to who reported being single ($n = 278$). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E7 shows that among single respondents, all political effects are statistically significant and broadly consistent with the main analysis in both direction and magnitude. The effects of the political attributes are slightly weaker here than in the main analysis (e.g., PRR affiliation -0.68 vs -0.71), except for out-bloc affiliation, which is somewhat stronger (-0.33 vs -0.27 in Model 4). The within R^2 is virtually identical across all models, and exactly the same in Model 4 (0.52).

Table E8 **Fixed-effects regression of the effects on relationship interest, respondents in a relationship**

	(1) Same party	(2) Ideological distance	(3) + Affective blocs	(4) + PRR
Same party affiliation	1.153*** (0.056)			
Ideological distance		-0.347*** (0.013)	-0.284*** (0.020)	-0.246*** (0.020)
Out-bloc affiliation			-0.349*** (0.092)	-0.222* (0.088)
PRR affiliation				-0.739*** (0.070)
2 years younger	-0.284*** (0.082)	-0.314*** (0.065)	-0.315*** (0.065)	-0.327*** (0.061)
2 years older	0.041 (0.079)	-0.038 (0.066)	-0.040 (0.065)	-0.065 (0.061)
Short	-0.213* (0.086)	-0.212** (0.067)	-0.208** (0.066)	-0.232*** (0.063)
Tall	0.024 (0.082)	0.101 (0.071)	0.096 (0.071)	0.080 (0.068)
University education	0.284*** (0.073)	0.261*** (0.058)	0.260*** (0.058)	0.255*** (0.055)
Observations	1545	1545	1545	1545
Within R^2	0.190	0.465	0.472	0.523

Note: Sample restricted to respondents who reported being in a relationship, cohabiting or married/registered partnership ($n = 309$). Respondent fixed effects are included in all models. Age difference, height, and education are included as dummy variables. Reference categories are same age, average height, and upper secondary education. Standard errors in parentheses, clustered at the respondent level. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E8 shows that among respondents currently in a relationship, all political effects are statistically significant and broadly consistent with the main analysis. In direct contrast to the results for single respondents, the effects of the political attributes are slightly stronger here than in the main analysis (e.g., PRR affiliation -0.74 vs -0.71), except for out-bloc affiliation,

which is somewhat weaker (-0.22 vs -0.27 in Model 4). In Model 4, the out-bloc affiliation does not reach the same level of significance as in the main analysis ($p < 0.05$ vs $p < 0.001$). As with single respondents, the within R^2 is virtually identical across all models, reaching 0.52 in Model 4.

Comparing single respondents with respondents in a relationship, the results are similar, with the exception of the out-bloc coefficient noted above. Most effects of the political attributes are somewhat stronger among respondents in a relationship compared to single respondents (e.g., PRR affiliation -0.74 vs -0.68), except for the out-bloc effect. Overall, though, relationship status does not appear to moderate the effects of direct political matching in any substantial way.

Appendix F. Nonpolitical profile attributes

This appendix provides brief theoretical background and analyzes the effects of the nonpolitical attributes in the vignette profiles. These include age difference, height, and education (as well as names, see Section 3.2.1). The levels included for each attribute are presented in Section 3.3.3 and will therefore not be accounted for here.

Age difference

Research on age preferences in human mating is remarkably consistent. While there is vast evidence for age homogamy on the aggregate level (e.g., Buss, 1984; Feng & Baker, 1994; Watson et al., 2004), a consistent gender asymmetry exists within this pattern. In his seminal study, Buss (1989) documents mate preferences across 33 countries and finds that men universally prefer younger women (by an average of 2.66 years), while women prefer older men (by an average of 3.42 years), a pattern reflected in marriage data from 27 countries. This pattern has since been replicated in more recent studies (e.g., Conroy-Beam & Buss, 2019; Hitsch et al., 2010; Walter et al., 2020). Among previous experimental studies on direct political matching, only Huber and Malhotra (2017) vary the age of the profiles, but they use fixed categories and therefore do not produce findings relevant to the present analysis.

In the main analysis, presented in Table 7, profiles that are two years younger than the respondent are consistently evaluated less favorably, with same age serving as the reference category. This effect is statistically significant across all models, with an estimated effect of 0.33 points lower evaluations in Model 4 ($p < 0.001$). The robustness test excluding respondents aged 18-19 (Table D6) yields the same pattern, suggesting that the age penalty is not simply driven by aversion toward profiles below the age of 18. There is no significant effect for profiles that are two years older than the respondent compared to same-age profiles.

To examine the gender differences documented in the literature, I next turn to the heterogeneity analyses by gender in Appendix E. Among female respondents (Table E5), the pattern is the same as in the main analyses. Model 4 indicates that profiles two years younger are evaluated 0.46 points lower, an effect that is statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), while no effect is found for older profiles. These findings only partially align with previous research suggesting that women prefer older partners (e.g., Buss, 1989). Female respondents show lower interest in younger profiles, but do not exhibit a corresponding preference for older profiles relative to same-age profiles. Among male respondents, no significant effects of age difference are observed, which contrast with patterns commonly documented in the literature.

Height

Physical characteristics represent a central dimension of mate preferences (e.g., Barber, 1995). As images were not included in the profiles (see Section 3.2), height was used to partially capture this dimension. Height homogamy, where taller individuals tend to pair with taller partners and vice versa, is well documented in both actual couples and stated preferences, though typically at low to moderate strength (e.g., Stulp et al., 2017). In addition, research identifies a male-taller norm, whereby women are generally shorter than their partners (Gillis & Avis, 1980). This is reflected in preferences: where men tend to prefer somewhat shorter partners, whereas women show a more consistent preference for taller men. At the aggregated level, this results in a pattern where women of average height and taller men are perceived as most attractive (Stulp & Barrett, 2016). In line with this, Sleiman et al. (2025), in a political matching context, find that women prefer tall profiles, while male participants show no significant height preference.

In the main analysis in Table 7, short profiles (170 cm for male profiles and 156 cm for female ones) receive a negative penalty in romantic interest compared to profiles of average height (180 cm for male profiles and 166 cm for female ones) which serves as the reference category. This effect is statistically significant across all models. In Model 4, short profiles are associated with a negative effect of 0.26 points lower evaluations ($p < 0.001$). Meanwhile, the results show no significant effect for tall profiles compared to average-height profiles.

Next, I examine gender differences in these effects. Among female respondents (Table E5), the negative effects associated with shorter profiles are somewhat more pronounced than in the main analysis, with 0.46 points lower evaluations in Model 4 ($p < 0.001$). In contrast to the main analysis, female respondents also evaluate tall profiles more favorably, with an increase of 0.16 points in Model 4 ($p < 0.01$) though this effect does not reach the same level of significance as the short profile penalty. Still, these effects are in line with the patterns found in previous research (Stulp & Barrett, 2016; Sleiman et al., 2025). Meanwhile, male respondents (Table E6) show no significant height effects, which contrasts with the notion that men at the aggregate level prefer women of average height (Stulp & Barrett, 2016).

Education

As with age and height, research on established couples consistently documents educational homogamy, often treated as a proxy for socioeconomic homogamy more broadly (Blossfeld, 2009; Feng & Baker, 1994; Kalmijn, 1998; Watson et al., 2004). Historically, women tended

to partner with more educated men, but this has reversed as women increasingly outnumber men in higher education (De Hauw et al., 2017). Stated preferences, however, paint a less consistent picture. Some studies find that both sexes prefer equally educated partners (Hitsch et al., 2010; Jonason & Antoon, 2019), whereas others suggest that women prefer more highly educated partners, while men are indifferent or even prefer less educated ones (Greitemeyer, 2007; Neyt et al., 2019). In their study of direct political matching, Sleiman et al. (2025) find that both men and women rate profiles with higher education more favorably.

In the main analysis, presented in Table 7, profiles with university education are evaluated more favorably than profiles with upper secondary education, which serves as the reference category. This effect is statistically significant across all models and corresponds to an increase of 0.23 in Model 4 ($p < 0.001$). The same pattern holds for both female (Table E5) and male respondents (Table E6), with an effect size of approximately 0.23 across both subgroups, in line with the findings of Sleiman et al. (2025). Among men, the estimate is slightly less precisely estimated, but remains statistically significant ($p < 0.01$).²⁶

²⁶ Note that, although the literature discusses educational homogamy (Blossfeld, 2009; Feng & Baker, 1994; Kalmijn, 1998; Watson et al., 2004), this cannot be directly operationalized in this study given that profiles only vary across two educational levels. Moreover, the subgroup with only upper secondary education is small ($n=57$), which implies limited statistical precision.

Appendix G. Survey recruitment poster

Figure G1 Survey recruitment poster



Note: The poster was produced in multiple formats: A4, A5 and A6 versions for distribution across university building, public libraries, public bulletin boards, cafes and bars, and adapted versions for digital distribution via Instagram, Facebook, and LinkedIn. For TikTok, a short video was shared instead.

Translation: Who would you choose to date? A study on how we evaluate potential partners. Are you between 18-35 years old? Take part in this survey where you get will be asked to evaluate personal profiles. You may participate whether you are single or not! About the survey: 5-10 min; All responses are anonymous. You can choose to withdraw at any time. The survey is part of a master's thesis. Scan the QR code to participate! Questions? Contact: gusolsemci@student.gu.se

Appendix H. Translated survey

Below is a translated version of the full survey. The coding in parentheses corresponds to descriptive statistics.

Master thesis

Start of block: Introduction

Introduction

Welcome!

This survey is part of a master's thesis that examines dating preferences. The survey takes approximately 5-10 minutes to complete.

The next page contains information on how personal data is processed. The survey will then begin.

Page break

Informed consent

Information on the processing of personal data for educational purposes at the University of Gothenburg and consent to participate in the work.

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) requires survey respondents to be informed about how their personal data will be processed. This text describes the purpose of the study you are participating in and what rights you have as a participant. The University of Gothenburg is responsible for the processing of personal data carried out by students within the framework of their studies. If you have any questions about the processing, you can contact the student who carries out the study.

Course code: SK2532

Student's work: Master's thesis

Student's name: Emma Olsson

Student's e-mail: gusolsemci@student.gu.se

The aim of the study is to examine factors that influence people's preferences and decisions in dating and relationships contexts. The study includes a sample of individuals aged 18-35. Personal data relating to sociodemographic background, political views, and sexual/romantic orientation will be processed within the scope of the study. Directly identifying personal data,

such as name, personal identification number, IP address, or similar information, will not be collected.

Only those persons who are involved in the work that the student performs for educational purposes at the University of Gothenburg are able to access your personal data (the student himself/herself and the supervisor/examiner).

Your answers will only be processed for the duration of the student's work for educational purposes. After the work has been completed, the student will delete the answers. This means that no personal data can be requested as a public document.

If you want to read a more detailed description of your rights under the GDPR and find contact details for the University's Data Protection Officer and the Swedish Authority for Privacy Protection, please visit [Processing personal data | University of Gothenburg](#).

By answering the survey, you give your consent. Your participation is voluntary, and you can withdraw your consent at any time until the work has been submitted.

End of block: Introduction

Start of block: Sociodemographic characteristics

Block introduction

First, a few introductory questions about yourself.



Q1 gender Are you:

- ☐ Female (1)
- ☐ Male (2)
- ☐ Other (3)
- ☐ Prefer not to specify (3)



Q2 age How old are you?



Q3 area What type of area do you live in?

- ☐ Large city (Gothenburg, Stockholm, Malmö) (1)
 - ☐ City or larger town (2)
 - ☐ Small town (3)
 - ☐ Countryside (3)
-



Q4 education Which is your highest level of education? If you have not yet completed your education, please select the one you are currently pursuing.

- ☐ Primary school or equivalent (1)
 - ☐ Upper secondary school or equivalent (1)
 - ☐ Tertiary education, not college/university (2)
 - ☐ College/university, 3 years or less (2)
 - ☐ College/university, longer than 3 years (3)
 - ☐ Postgraduate education (3)
-



Q5 attention check For this question, please select the response option “Strongly disagree”

- ☐ Strongly agree (1)
 - ☐ Somewhat agree (2)
 - ☐ Somewhat disagree (3)
 - ☐ Strongly disagree (4)
-



Q6 marital status What is your marital status?

- ☐ Single (1)
- ☐ In a relationship (2)
- ☐ Cohabitant (3)
- ☐ Married/in a registered partnership (4)

End of block: Sociodemographic characteristics

Start of block: Political characteristics



Q7 party Rank the eight parliamentary parties, from your best party to your worst party.

- _____ Left Party (1)
- _____ Green Party (2)

- _____ Social Democrats (3)
 - _____ Center Party (4)
 - _____ Liberals (5)
 - _____ Moderates (6)
 - _____ Christian Democrats (7)
 - _____ Sweden Democrats (8)
-



Q8 partisanship Do you consider yourself a convinced supporter of your best party?

- ☐ Yes, very convinced (1)
- ☐ Yes, somewhat convinced (2)
- ☐ No (3)

End of block: Political characteristics

Start of block: Sexual/romantic orientation

Block introduction

You will now be shown five dating profiles and asked to answer two question about each person. If you are currently in a relationship, please answer the question as if you were single, that is, based on how you generally are attracted to people.

In order for the gender of the persons in the profiles to match your preferences, you will first need to indicate which people you are interested in. The profiles only display individuals who identify as male or female, although gender identity may extend beyond these categories.

If you select “Both men and women” or “Prefer not to specify”, you will randomly be shown only male or only female profiles.



Q9 attraction Which persons are you romantically and/or sexually attracted to

- ☐ Only men (1)
- ☐ Only women (2)
- ☐ Both men and women (3)
- ☐ Prefer not to specify (4)

End of block: Sexual/romantic orientation

Start of block: Randomization of name/age



Randomization .Skin .QuestionOuter, .Skin #Buttons { display: none !important; }

Loading profiles...

End of block: Randomization of name/age

Start of block: Profile 1

JS

Profile 1 Loading profile...

X→

Q10 profile 1 [\\${e://Field/single}](#) interested would you be in:

	Not interested at all (1)	Not very interested (2)	Neither interested nor uninterested (3)	Somewhat interested (4)	Very interested (5)
Going on a date with the person in this profile? (Q10_1)	0	0	0	0	0
Pursuing a romantic relationship with the person in this profile? (Q10_2)	0	0	0	0	0

End of block: Profile 1

Start of block: Profile 2

JS

Profile 2 Loading profile...

X→

Q11 profile 2 [\\${e://Field/single}](#) interested would you be in:

	Not interested at all (1)	Not very interested (2)	Neither interested nor uninterested (3)	Somewhat interested (4)	Very interested (5)
Going on a date with the person in this profile? (Q11_1)	0	0	0	0	0
Pursuing a romantic relationship with the person in this profile? (Q11_2)	0	0	0	0	0

End of block: Profile 2

Start of block: Profile 3



Profile 3 Loading profile...



Q12 profile 3 [\\${e://Field/single}](#) interested would you be in:

	Not interested at all (1)	Not very interested (2)	Neither interested nor uninterested (3)	Somewhat interested (4)	Very interested (5)
Going on a date with the person in this profile? (Q12_1)	0	0	0	0	0
Pursuing a romantic relationship with the person in this profile? (Q12_2)	0	0	0	0	0

End of block: Profile 3

Start of block: Profile 4

JS

Profile 4 Loading profile...

X→

Q13 profile 4 [\\${e://Field/single}](#) interested would you be in:

	Not interested at all (1)	Not very interested (2)	Neither interested nor uninterested (3)	Somewhat interested (4)	Very interested (5)
Going on a date with the person in this profile? (Q13_1)	0	0	0	0	0
Pursuing a romantic relationship with the person in this profile? (Q13_2)	0	0	0	0	0

End of block: Profile 4

Start of block: Profile 5

JS

Profile 5 Loading profile...

X→

Q14 profile 5 [\\${e://Field/single}](#) interested would you be in

	Not interested at all (1)	Not very interested (2)	Neither interested nor uninterested (3)	Somewhat interested (4)	Very interested (5)

Going on a date with the person in this profile?
(Q14_1)

0 0 0 0 0

Pursuing a romantic relationship with the person in this profile?
(Q14_2)

0 0 0 0 0

End of block: Profile 5

Start of block: Political similarity importance



Q15 shared politics How important is it to share the same political views as your partner?

- ☐ Very important (1)
- ☐ Somewhat important (2)
- ☐ Not very important (3)
- ☐ Not important at all (4)

End of block: Political similarity importance

Start of block: Debrief

Debrief

Thank you for taking the time to complete the survey!

This survey included an experiment with the aim of examining how political similarity influences interest and choice in dating contexts. The profiles you were shown varied in party affiliation based on the party you placed at the top of your ranking of the parties. All profiles in the survey are fictional.

If you have any questions, comments, or would like to receive the results of the study, please feel free to contact gusolsemci@student.gu.se.

Q16 feedback You are also very welcome to provide potential feedback here:

Page break



Invite to share

All responses are valuable! If you would like to help spread the survey further, you can copy the link by clicking the button below.

End of block: Debrief

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